

Crude rises to \$91/bbl as traders weigh slew of risks from Hormuz to Red Sea

OIL ON THE BOIL. Brent could exceed \$120 a barrel by Q4 if Hormuz disruptions persist, says Goldman Sachs

Bloomberg

Brent crude oil extended its recent rally as traders weighed threats to maritime traffic from the Strait of Hormuz and the Red Sea to a key Kazakh export terminal on Russia's coast. The global benchmark traded around \$91 a barrel.

US STRIKES CONTINUE

The US conducted a 10th straight day of strikes on Iran.

Away from West Asia, there have also been disruptions after a spate of attacks at the Caspian Pipeline Consortium terminal on Russia's Black Sea coast, which ships most of Kazakhstan's oil. The Central Asian nation has at times shipped close to 1.8

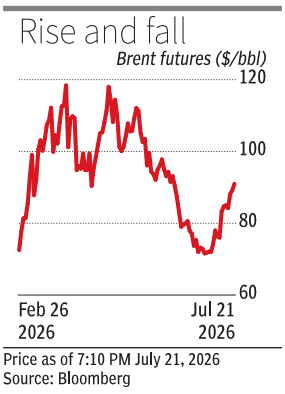
million barrels a day of crude, making it a significant global exporter.

Oil has repeatedly swung on the prospects for escalation and détente in the conflict, making for increasingly choppy price moves.

HOUTHI THREAT

The Houthi threat could open up a new front in the conflict, dragging prices higher just weeks after oil markets looked to have averted the worst-case impacts of the Iran war.

"If there's a disruption in the infrastructure, particularly the shipping lanes, then that could cause a spike in oil prices," said Rob Thummel, Senior Portfolio Manager at Tortoise Capital, referring to the Houthi threat. "Inventories have drawn down a bit,



so there's just not a lot of margin for error."

Saudi exports from Yanbu hit record levels in the days and weeks before the Houthis threatened to block the kingdom's shipments.

The Saudi Foreign Ministry said it would take all ne-

There have also been disruptions after a spate of attacks at the Caspian Pipeline Consortium terminal on Russia's Black Sea coast, which ships most of Kazakhstan's oil

cessary measures to protect its ships in accordance with international law. Brent could exceed \$120 a barrel by the fourth quarter if Hormuz disruptions persist, according to Goldman Sachs Group, although that's not the bank's base case.

At present, Goldman sees \$80 in the final three months of the year, with the Houthi threat adding to upside risks to the forecast.

IRANIAN ATTACKS

Traffic through Hormuz came to a standstill on Monday following Iranian attacks on vessels over the weekend. An oil supertanker, *Acheloos*, and a smaller fuel tanker were struck in the waterway, according to Dynacom Tankers Management, the ships' manager.

The flare-up in violence around the waterway has prompted shipowners to offer huge bonuses to get crews to sail through Hormuz. Sinokor Group has offered six months' extra salary if seafarers make a return voyage.

Bahrain, Kuwait come under attack after US hits Iranian ports and cities

Reuters
Dubai

US forces bombed Iran's south and west after President Donald Trump said Tehran would pay dearly for the deaths of American soldiers, while Iran targeted US sites in Bahrain, Kuwait and Jordan on Tuesday and a tanker was hit in the Strait of Hormuz.

Yemen's Iran-aligned Houthis announced a naval blockade on Saudi Arabia on Monday, opening a potential new front in the war and raising the threat to global energy supplies and trade beyond the Gulf.

Shipping companies loading or discharging cargo at Saudi ports could be targeted "in any location" by Houthis, according to an e-mail sent to companies on Monday and seen by Reuters.

Explosions were heard around the city of Shiraz in

southern Iran, state media said. Konarak and Chabahar on the southern coast, the city of Khorramabad and a civilian site outside the city of Abadan, both in the west, all came under attack, media reports said.

Later, the IRNA news agency quoted an official in Khorramabad as saying that no enemy attack had taken place there.

WORLDWIDE CAUTION

Fifty civilians have been killed and 500 wounded in the recent US strikes on Iran, a Health Ministry official said.

As hostilities spread across the region, the US State Department issued a new "worldwide caution" for Americans due to "heightened tensions in West Asia".

Iran launched renewed attacks across the Gulf, where recent strikes on desalination facilities have raised

concerns about water shortages.

Attacks on Kuwaiti power generation and water desalination plants on Monday caused several generation units to be taken out of service as a precautionary measure and repairs were underway, authorities said.

Iran's Revolutionary Guards said they targeted infrastructure in Bahrain belonging to US tech company Amazon in response to what they described as a US strike on the construction site of Iran's planned Darkhovin nuclear power plant.

Iranian state media reported that Iranian forces also targeted accommodation facilities of US military personnel at Bahrain's Sheikh Isa Air Base.

There was no immediate comment from the US military, Bahrain or Amazon on the reported incidents, which Reuters was unable to verify.

Punjab & Sind Bank expects FCNR(B) norm relaxations for banks without foreign branches

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Punjab & Sind Bank expects the Reserve Bank of India to grant regulatory relaxations on FCNR(B) deposits to support lenders operating without overseas branches. Meanwhile, the state-run bank has outlined a long-term strategy to expand its total business mix to ₹4-lakh crore by FY29.

"We have given a feeler to the RBI on this matter; how it can be simplified a bit more so that banks without for-

eign branches can also leverage this," Swarup Kumar Saha, Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer of Punjab & Sind Bank, told *businessline*. The bank has set a target to collect \$25 million through FCNR(B) and another \$75 million through External Commercial Borrowing (ECB) and Overseas Foreign Currency Borrowings (OFCBs).

OFCB ROUTE

Banks are raising funds via the OFCB route to provide leverage to their NRI customers who, in turn, can

place proceeds of the leverage as FCNR (B) deposits with them. Concessional swaps for OFCB and ECB inflows are available till December 31.

"It is those banks that have a foreign branch that are in advantageous position because depositors who want to put in money would like to leverage it to that extent. As of now, we are constrained by not having a foreign branch," said Saha.

Further, he said that the regulator will look into it. "In what form it will come, I don't know, but we expect



The vision of the bank now is *Viksit Bharat ka Vishwasiniya Bank* (trusted bank of developed nation)

SWARUP KUMAR SAHA
MD & CEO, Punjab & Sind Bank

some relaxation somewhere so that we can tap that market also."

Giving the example of Canada, where a large num-



ber of Sikhs NROs reside, he said: "We don't have our presence there. So, our customers may shift to other banks, but we are still trying

whatever best we can do," he said.

Q1 NET RISES 23%

Meanwhile, the bank reported a 23 per cent rise in net profit at ₹331 crore for the June quarter. At the end of the quarter, the net interest margin (NIM) was at 2.53 per cent. Now, Saha expects further improvement in this area.

"In the June quarter, our net interest income growth was 15 per cent. We feel that downward cycle stabilisation has reached its bottom now. We should have an up-

tick, so our NIM should improve," he said, adding that for the current fiscal the target is 2.65 per cent. Saha informed that the bank has a new vision that derives strength from the *Viksit Bharat* goals of the government.

"The vision of the bank is *Viksit Bharat ka Vishwasiniya Bank* (trusted bank of developed nation)," he said. It will have a customer-centric service built on trust and transparency and excellence through technology and innovation. Also, there is mid-term plan where the bank

aims to have ₹4-lakh crore business by FY29, from ₹2.66-lakh crore as of June 30, 2026. We aim to have 2,000-plus branches, 1,600 ATMs and 6,000-plus business correspondents," he said.

TO RAISE FUNDS

Saha said the bank aims to raise ₹2,000 crore through qualified institutional placement. "We are in discussions with merchant bankers to test the appetite in the market, and we will go to the market at the appropriate time," he added.

'US tariff policy wildly successful, more coming'

Press Trust of India
Washington

The US tariff policy has been "wildly successful," and the Trump administration was planning such measures to replace those overturned by the Supreme Court, said US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer.

Greer, in an interview with *The New York Times*, said the Trump administration had changed the US trade policy of 70 years in the past year, and the new measures had resulted in reducing the trade deficit and reshoring of businesses.

"They are. Yeah. I think we've been wildly successful," said Greer to a question on whether the tariff regime was delivering results.

TRADE DEFICIT

Greer said the administration acted quickly because it viewed America's widening trade deficit as an economic emergency that required decisive action.



US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer

"At the end of the day, we are winning in changing the trade policy. We're winning in getting the trade deficit down. We're winning in reshoring. We're winning in wages. We're winning on all these things. So, I'm happy with where we are and where we're going," he said in the interview published on Monday.

According to the *New York Times*, the Trump administration was working to recreate the tariffs struck down by the Supreme Court with the

levies planned on countries using forced labour in manufacturing and surplus production.

Greer contended that broad tariffs had allowed the US to negotiate new trade arrangements with several partners. The US trade chief said the tariff policy was driven purely through an economic perspective, instead of a foreign policy approach.

"This is not a foreign policy shop. This is an economics shop here. And so when I look at someone like the European Union that blocks American agricultural goods for specious, non-scientific reasons, that's a problem. Friend or foe, that's an issue," he said in response to a question that the tariff policy was hard on traditional allies.

DEALS SIGNED

Greer said the administration's approach had helped the US negotiate trade deals with the UK, the European Union, Indonesia, India and

Japan. He said that the Supreme Court had struck down a significant portion of the administration's tariff programme, but insisted he had no regrets about the strategy.

"No, I don't have any — well, I regret that the Supreme Court went the wrong way. But I mean, that's their fault. That's not ours," said Greer when asked whether he had any regrets about the legal strategy on tariffs.

He said the administration was already pursuing alternative legal authorities to preserve its trade agenda and remained committed to fundamentally changing decades of US trade policy. "We're not really about going out and changing the world. We're trying to change the terms of trade," he said.

"It does mean, to the extent we have to take measures in other countries, we will. But it's less that we're anti any particular country and more we are just pro-America," said Greer.

MONSOON MAYHEM



DEEP DIVIDE. Commuters queue up near a major road cave-in on the Dehradun-Mussoorie road after heavy rain on Tuesday. The Public Works Department restored limited connectivity through a temporary diversion, allowing restricted vehicular movement while repair works continue. The Char Dham Yatra, temporarily suspended due to incessant rain and landslides, resumed on Tuesday.

On the razor's edge of enterprise with the Edison of India

With the biopic on GD Naidu set to release, his grandson recalls the genius's quest for industrial self-reliance

Shakthi H
Chennai

On August 7, when the biopic *GDN* chronicling the life of Coimbatore inventor Gopalswamy Doraiswamy Naidu releases, it will spotlight the work of the grassroots genius, popularly known as the Edison of India.

Think of some of the essential early technologies in India and GDN had a hand in them, displaying ingenuity to invent ingenious solutions. On a visit to Europe, Naidu found himself working briefly in a bakery, where watching bread being sliced with a reciprocating blade — one that goes back and forth — sparked an idea that would eventually become the Rasant Electric Razor.

The story goes — narrated in his son GD Gopal's biography of Naidu — that he returned to his room, dismantled a toy

electric car, took out its motor, fastened it to a razor with rubber bands, and created a vibrating prototype. Friends who tried it praised the smooth shave and encouraged him to manufacture it commercially.

CORE PATRIOT

According to Naidu's grandson GD Rajkumar, who is Trustee, GD Naidu Charities, when an American company offered to purchase the razor patent, he refused out of "patriotic fervour".

The biography records that he wanted "the benefits of my efforts to accrue only to India", reflecting his belief that innovation should strengthen indigenous industry, rather than simply generate profit overseas.

That philosophy extended beyond manufacturing. Rajkumar said Naidu established an intensive two-year polytechnic course because



Gopalswamy Doraiswamy Naidu GD CHARITIES

he believed there is nothing better than understanding how science works.

The institution's specialised technical courses, he said, enabled many graduates to become entrepreneurs and establish workshops of their own.

Naidu also encouraged industrial collaborations.

Rajkumar recalled that when industrialists approached him to establish what would later become CODISSIA (the Coimbatore District Small Industries Association), Naidu offered them space on his campus free of cost to help the association take shape.

Similarly, he supported the Indian Chamber of Commerce by donating land for its building, believing that industry advanced through shared institutions as much as individual enterprise.

MANY OBSTACLES

Yet, his ambition to build industries in India often met bureaucratic obstacles.

Akila Shannmugam, Trustee, GD Naidu Charities, recalled that his proposed collaboration to manufacture trucks in Coimbatore faced licensing

and taxation hurdles.

His battle with the Income Tax Department prevented him from getting most of the licences he required.

Naidu ran into a similar wall years later. According to Shannmugam, he had purchased land and imported engines from Daimler-Benz — today Mercedes-Benz — to manufacture trucks in Coimbatore, but the plan collapsed after officials "levied a huge tax".

PROBLEM SOLVER

For Naidu, innovation began with curiosity — the instinct to question, observe and solve practical problems.

From manufacturing components for his transport business to creating skill-based education, he believed learning came through doing, an approach that remains relevant as India looks to become a deep-tech manufacturing hub.

Novo sues Lilly, claiming 'false' ads in weight-loss drug battle

Reuters
London

Novo Nordisk sued rival Eli Lilly in a US federal court on Tuesday, accusing the US drugmaker of false advertising in claiming its weight-loss medicines outperform Novo's drugs.

The Danish company filed the lawsuit in US district court in New Jersey, alleging Lilly violated federal and state false advertising and unfair competition laws, including the Lanham Act, through nationwide advertising campaigns for obesity drug Zepbound and diabetes treatment Mounjaro.

Novo alleges Lilly compared the highest approved doses of its medicines with lower doses of Novo's Wegovy and Ozempic while omitting newer, higher-dose versions that Novo says deliver greater weight loss.

Indianapolis-based Eli Lilly did not immediately respond to a request for com-

ment. "The ads are maliciously and deceptively false because Lilly knowingly cites outdated clinical trials that compare the highest doses of the Lilly medicines to lower doses of Novo Nordisk's medicines," Novo wrote in its complaint.

FIERCE BATTLE

Novo and Lilly are locked in a fierce battle for dominance in the US obesity drug market, which analysts expect to be worth more than \$100 billion by 2030.

The US is one of only a handful of countries that allow pharmaceutical companies to advertise prescription medicines directly to consumers. Drugmakers spend billions of dollars every year on television and other advertising.

LOSES LEAD

Novo was first to market with weight-loss injection Wegovy, but later lost the lead to Lilly's rival Zepbound.

After replacing its CEO and issuing multiple profit warnings last year, Novo has landed a counter punch with oral Wegovy, whose strong demand has held up despite the launch of Lilly's competing pill.

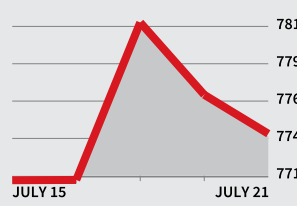
Novo said it is seeking a court order requiring Lilly to withdraw the advertisements and run a corrective advertising campaign. It added that it plans to seek a preliminary injunction if Lilly does not voluntarily remove the ads.

Novo is also seeking damages, including Lilly's profits that can be attributed to the ads. Novo said it sent Lilly a cease-and-desist letter in April after the US approved a 7.2-milligram dose of Wegovy.

Lilly did not respond to the letter. Novo's general counsel John Kuckelman told Reuters, adding that the company instead inserted what he described as an inadequate disclaimer into the advertisements.

the hindu businessline

SENSEX 77470.11 (-238.41)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	24187.70	-50.80
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.83	-0.07
US Dollar (in ₹)	96.23	-0.21
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	142564.00	+880
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	223204.00	+3629

INDIA, THE BEACON.

IFC's V-P for Asia and Pacific Survesh Suri says India is a lighthouse for development, financing models for emerging markets **p10**



POLICY WATCH.

Nickel rebounds but its price direction will be determined by Indonesia's mining policy **p8**

QUICKLY.

STEADY LISTING

SBI Funds makes decent debut, ends 6.2% higher



Mumbai: India's largest mutual fund house, SBI Funds Management, made a steady stock market debut on Tuesday, listing at a premium before giving up part of its early gains as investors locked into profits. The stock closed at ₹609.75 on the NSE, down 0.58 per cent from its listing price of ₹613.30 but 6.2 per cent over its IPO price of ₹574; the stock climbed to an intra-day high of ₹624.80. The market capitalisation of SBI Funds stood at ₹1.24 lakh crore. **p6**

BIG IMPACT

PLI schemes attracted ₹2.4 lakh cr till March

New Delhi: The government's flagship Production Linked Incentive (PLI) schemes attracted investments of more than ₹2.4 lakh crore, generated over 14.15 lakh jobs and enabled cumulative exports worth over ₹15.2 lakh crore till March 31, 2026, highlighting the growing impact of the programme on India's manufacturing and export sectors. **p3**

To support rupee, NPS may be opened to NRI, OCI dollars

DRAFT FOREX RULES. New foreign investment norm to allow direct overseas listing

Our Bureau

Mumbai

To bolster the recent government and RBI measures to attract foreign capital, plans are under consideration to allow non-resident Indians (NRIs) and overseas citizens of India (OCIs) to subscribe to the National Pension System (NPS).

This proposal needs to be viewed in the context of measures announced by the government and the RBI last month to attract foreign capital. These include expanding the list of 'specified securities' under the fully accessible route (FAR), increasing investment limits for NRIs and OCIs in listed equities, and the RBI bearing the full hedging cost for banks raising fresh 3/5-year FCNR (B) deposits.

EYEING DOLLARS

These measures are aimed at attracting dollar flows and supporting the rupee, which is facing pressure from rising crude oil prices and foreign portfolio investor (FPI) outflows from the equity markets amid the ongoing West Asia conflict.

Assets under management (AUM) under the NPS stood

LIBERAL PROPOSALS

- Opening NPS will encourage long-term participation by overseas Indians in the country's financial markets and attract stable foreign capital
- Direct overseas listing would expand Indian firms' access to global capital, improve valuations, enhance liquidity and visibility
- FDI is defined as a 10%+ stake, while FPI covers investments below 10%, providing regulatory clarity



at ₹17.27 lakh crore as of June-end. Of the total corpus, subscriptions from State government employees accounted for 51 per cent, followed by Central government employees (25 per cent), the corporate sector (17 per cent), the all-citizens category (5 per cent) and the Unified Pension Scheme - Central Government (2 per cent).

"A person resident outside India, being an NRI or an OCI, may subscribe to the NPS governed and administered by the Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority (PFRDA). The annuity or accumulated savings will be repatriable," according to the Draft Foreign Exchange Management (Foreign Investment) Rules, 2026.

Akshat Khetan, Founder, AU Corporate Advisory and Legal Services, said the draft FEMA (Foreign Investment) Rules, 2026, represent a significant liberalisation of India's foreign investment regime.

"Allowing NRIs and OCIs to invest in the NPS with repatriable benefits is a strategic move to encourage long-term participation by overseas Indians in the country's financial markets and attract stable foreign capital rather than short-term flows," he said.

DIRECT LISTING

The proposed rules, which seek to create a more modern and investor-friendly framework for foreign investments, will allow a public company to issue equity

shares or offer existing shareholders' equity on international stock exchanges, subject to specified conditions.

Khetan said the proposal would expand access to global capital, improve valuations, enhance liquidity and visibility and reduce dependence on domestic markets, while continuing to retain sectoral caps and regulatory safeguards.

According to the draft rules, a person resident outside India or a foreign controlled entity (FCE) may invest in an eligible Indian entity on either a repatriable or non-repatriable basis through subscription to new issues, purchase of securities, gifts between natural persons or pledge of securities.

The rules also draw a clear distinction between different types of foreign investments:

Foreign direct investment (FDI) refers to foreign investment of 10 per cent or more in the equity of a company or a limited liability partnership (LLP); and

Foreign portfolio investment refers to foreign investment of less than 10 per cent in the equity of a company or LLP.

EVs, exports drive record profits for TVS Motor, Bajaj Auto in Q1

Amit Vijay Mohile

Mumbai

TVS Motor and Bajaj Auto posted record quarterly profits in Q1 FY27, with electric vehicles, exports and premium motorcycles helping offset higher input costs and drive growth.

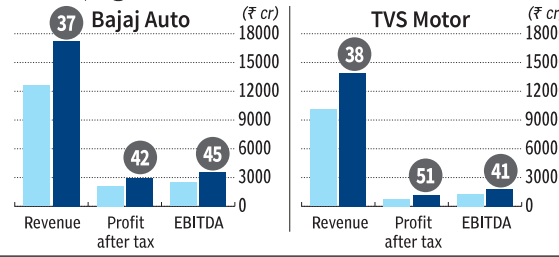
TVS Motor's profit after tax rose 51 per cent to ₹1,174 crore, while revenue jumped 38 per cent to ₹13,896 crore. Bajaj Auto's standalone profit increased 42 per cent to ₹2,983 crore, with revenue rising 37 per cent to ₹17,244 crore.

The results highlight two distinct growth strategies. TVS is leveraging premium scooters, EVs and international markets to expand its consumer franchise, while Bajaj is banking on exports, premium motorcycles, electric three-wheelers and KTM to strengthen profitability and protect margins.

TVS' EV SALES SURGE

TVS Motor's electric two-wheeler sales surged 86 per cent to 1,29,940 units in Q1 FY27, while scooter sales increased 36 per cent. International sales grew 33 per cent to 4.68 lakh units, providing a strong second growth engine beyond its domestic business. The company, however, faced rising commodity costs, with the cost of

In top gear



materials consumed climbing 45 per cent year-on-year on a standalone basis. TVS said it is offsetting the impact through selective price hikes, a better product and geographic mix, cost optimisation and scale efficiencies.

TVS CEO K N Radhakrishnan said domestic demand is expected to remain robust in the July-September quarter, supported by GST rationalisation, tax relief and improved affordability. "Overall, the outlook remains very, very strong," he said.

Morgan Stanley noted that TVS Motor expanded its EBITDA margin to 12.8 per cent from 12.5 per cent despite raw material inflation, reflecting pricing power and cost discipline.

EXPORTS STEER BAJAJ

For Bajaj Auto, EVs now contribute nearly 30 per cent of domestic revenue, while the demand for the Chetak scooter has exceeded production capacity. It plans to

increase annual production capacity by more than 25 per cent, from around 7 million units to more than 9 million.

Export volumes crossed 7 lakh units for the first time, supported by strong demand in Latin America and a recovery in Africa. Nigeria recorded three-fold growth.

Analysts attributed the performance to robust volume growth, price increases, operational efficiencies, favourable export mix and rupee depreciation.

"We want the leadership position, but it's not going to be at the cost of compromising the bottom line," Bajaj Auto Executive Director Rakesh Sharma said. Bajaj plans to launch 10 new or upgraded motorcycles over the next six weeks.

Meanwhile, TVS is expanding EV, three-wheeler and export capacity to cater to growing demand across Africa, Latin America and other emerging markets.

Also read **p2**



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Mutual Fund investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully.

QUICKLY.

Granules Q1 net profit rises 60% to ₹180 crore

Hyderabad: Granules India's net profit increased 60 per cent to ₹180 crore in the first quarter of the current fiscal ended June 30, 2026 compared to ₹112 crore. The total revenue of the company increased 22 per cent to ₹1,477 crore against ₹1,210 crore in the year-ago period. **OUR BUREAU**

Hatsun Agro Product Q1 PAT flat on higher costs

Chennai: Hatsun Agro Product reported a 1.5 per cent decline in profit after tax at ₹133 crore for the quarter ending June 2026, as against ₹135 crore for the same quarter last year on higher costs. This was despite a robust 19 per cent growth in revenue from operations during the quarter to ₹3,093 crore as against ₹2,251 crore. The company reported a marked increase in the cost of materials consumed at ₹2,156 crore, up 37 per cent from ₹1,570 crore. **OUR BUREAU**

Arvind Fashions reports 24% drop in net profit



Ahmedabad: Arvind Fashions Ltd reported a 24 per cent year-on-year decline in first-quarter net profit despite a 15 per cent rise in revenue. The profit attributable to equity holders of the parent declined to ₹9.57 crore in the April-June quarter of FY27 from ₹12.57 crore in the corresponding period last year. Revenue from operations, however, increased 15 per cent to ₹1,278 crore. **OUR BUREAU**

Bajaj Auto seeks strategic partner for KTM; plans new models, EV expansion

UPBEAT. Despite recent supply chain disruptions, firm remains optimistic about sustaining export momentum

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Bajaj Auto is open to considering a strategic partner for KTM if an interested investor's vision is aligned with that of the global motorcycle brand, Executive Director Rakesh Sharma said during a post-results interaction with the media.

KTM has returned to EBITDA break-even after several difficult quarters. Bajaj Auto also plans to launch 10 new or upgraded motorcycles, expand its electric-vehicle portfolio and raise annual production capacity in India by more than 25 per cent.

The strategy follows a record first quarter, although supply-chain disruptions and capacity constraints prevented the company from fully meeting demand for exports, electric vehicles, higher-capacity motorcycles



Rakesh Sharma, Executive Director, Bajaj Auto

and selected three-wheelers.

Bajaj Auto took effective control of KTM in November 2025 after its the Netherlands-based subsidiary acquired Pierer Bajaj AG for €800 million. The transaction gave Bajaj Auto an effective 74.9 per cent controlling stake in Pierer Mobility AG and KTM AG, making KTM a step-down subsidiary.

Sharma said KTM continues to operate independently and is not being integrated into Bajaj Auto. Bajaj

has injected liquidity, supported the appointment of new leadership and improved sourcing from competitive locations, including India.

"It has broken even at EBITDA, and now it will keep going progressively," Sharma said, adding that KTM would continue to improve its topline and bottomline.

Bajaj Auto will raise annual production capacity from 7.11 million units, or 71.1 lakh, to more than nine

million units over the next few quarters. The expansion of more than 25 per cent will support demand for EVs, exports, higher-capacity motorcycles and selected three-wheelers.

Bajaj Auto's record Q1 performance came despite inflation, supply-chain disruptions and international logistics problems. Sharma estimated that availability was impaired by 10-15 per cent during the quarter.

QUARTERLY VOLUMES

"If everything was normal, we could have been 10 to 15 per cent more than what we achieved," he said, adding that quarterly volumes could have crossed 1.5 million units.

Bajaj Auto has upgraded around eight motorcycle models since November-December, particularly in the 150-160cc segment. Growth in the segment dur-

ing Q4 and Q1 was around 1.5 times the industry's growth, based on vehicle registrations.

Over the next six weeks, the company plans to introduce around 10 additional models, including motorcycles in the 125cc and 150-160cc categories. The new range will be rolled out from August, with a completely refreshed portfolio expected by the festive season.

Bajaj Auto is targeting the number-one position in electric two-wheelers after emerging as the second-largest player in Q1.

"We want the leadership position, but it's not going to be at the cost of compromising the bottom line," Sharma said.

The company now has 12 EV models. Electric vehicles account for about 24 per cent of industry scooter sales and 45 per cent of three-wheeler sales, he said.

Wipro Consumer Care to acquire Philippines' S Brands

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

Wipro Consumer Care International is set to acquire Philippine-based S Brands Consumer Care Inc, marking its 16th acquisition globally, and second acquisition in the Philippines. With this acquisition, the company will further strengthen its personal care portfolio, while deepening its presence across South-East Asia.

Wipro Consumer Care & Lighting, which ended FY26 with revenues of ₹10,800 crore, witnessed double-digit growth in the June quarter, with the India busi-

ness alone recording a growth of 15.1 per cent.

Kumar Chander, CEO of Wipro Consumer Care & Lighting and Managing Director, Wipro Enterprises, told *businessline*, "As part of our strategy to double down on high-growth developing markets, we are acquiring S Brands Consumer Care in the Philippines, which will now become our third largest market outside of India with revenues exceeding ₹1,000 crore plus, after Malaysia and China. Together with Splash, it further strengthens our presence in the Philippines and provides opportunities to accelerate growth, deepen market



Kumar Chander, CEO of WCCLG and MD of Wipro Enterprises, and Anita Zutshi, CFO, Wipro Enterprises

reach and build scale across our personal care business."

RIGHT VALUATION

"S Brands' hair conditioner brand KERATINplus is the largest brand in the segment in the market, with 45 per cent market share. We also

hope to take learnings in the hair conditioning category from the Philippines to other Asian markets," he added.

The acquisition will also help the company strengthen its presence in rubbing alcohol, deodorants and fragrances categories.

+ Retailers clock 6 per cent sales growth y-o-y in June on steady consumer demand: RAI

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

Retailers clocked 6 per cent sales growth in June year-on-year (y-o-y) as per latest estimates by the Retailers Association of India (RAI) indicating steady consumer demand despite cautious spending environment. The growth was led by food and grocery, and quick-service restaurants.

The industry body said that while consumers continue to spend selectively, demand remains resilient for essential and experience-led categories.

While sales in food and grocery segment was up 10



per cent in June this year compared to last, sales of quick-service restaurants was up 9 per cent.

Footwear segment sales was up 8 per cent y-o-y while consumer durables and electronics segment recorded 7 per cent growth. Jewellery and apparel & clothing each grew 6 per cent, sales of

beauty and wellness segment was up 5 per cent. Sports goods segment grew 4 per cent but furniture and furnishings grew a mere 1 per cent.

SHARP VALUE

Kumar Rajagopalan, Executive Director and CEO, RAI, said, "While the intent to spend remains intact among Indian consumers, they are highly value-conscious, prompting retailers to pivot strategies quickly to sustain growth. Retailers are adapting with sharp value and efficiency and preparing for the upcoming festive season."

He added that retailers are maintaining disciplined inventory management, in-

vesting in technology-enabled decision-making, and strengthening omnichannel capabilities to improve customer engagement and operational efficiency. "Promotional strategies, value offerings, and digital transformation continue to play a critical role in sustaining growth amid evolving consumer preferences," the industry body said.

Retailers in the Western region reported growth of about 8 per cent and 7 per cent in the Northern region. Southern region and Eastern region reported sales growth of 6 per cent and 4 per cent respectively in June this year compared to same period last year.

Ashok Leyland's remuneration to top executives sees sharp surge; CEO pay jumps 49 per cent

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Ashok Leyland's remuneration to its top executives increased sharply in FY26, according to the company's annual report filed with the stock exchanges on Monday.

Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer Shenu Agarwal's total remuneration rose 49 per cent to ₹18.32 crore from ₹12.30 crore. His pay included short-term employee benefits of ₹18.16 crore and other long-term employee benefits of ₹0.16 crore.

Chief Financial Officer (CFO) KM Balaji recorded the sharpest increase among the executives. His total re-

muneration rose to ₹7.45 crore from ₹4.72 crore, an increase of nearly 58 per cent.

Balaji became CFO in June 2024 and is now proposed to be appointed as Whole-time Director and CFO.

Executive Chairman Dheeraj G Hinduja's total remuneration rose more moderately to ₹31.25 crore from ₹28.73 crore, an increase of about 9 per cent.

His short-term employee benefits stood at ₹31.17 crore, compared with ₹28.65 crore in FY25.

However, Hinduja's separate commission and sitting fees increased 65 per cent to ₹1.32 crore from ₹0.80 crore.

The aggregate commission and sitting fees paid to

other directors rose 26 per cent to ₹11.69 crore from ₹9.30 crore.

Remuneration for Whole-time Director Gopal Mahadevan declined to ₹13.73 crore from ₹14.65 crore. His FY25 remuneration included ₹0.84 crore in share-based payment, which was not recorded in FY26.

PROPOSED PACKAGES

The annual report also contains proposed remuneration terms for the next appointments of Hinduja and Balaji.

For Hinduja's proposed three-year term as Executive Chairman, the company has proposed fixed compensation of ₹15.50 crore per an-

num, along with annual performance pay and commission of ₹1.750 crore.

If fully paid, the potential annual package of Hinduja would be ₹33 crore before additional perquisites and allowances.

For Balaji's proposed term as Whole-time Director and CFO, the proposed fixed compensation is ₹3.85 crore per annum, with an additional ₹1.65 crore in annual performance pay and commission.

The proposed terms allow the Nomination and Remuneration Committee and the Board to vary compensation during the tenure, subject to statutory limits and required approvals.

Adani Total Gas Q1 profit slumps 14% to ₹142 crore on higher costs

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad

Adani Total Gas Ltd, one of India's leading city gas distribution companies engaged in the supply of compressed natural gas (CNG) and piped natural gas (PNG), reported a 14 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) decline in consolidated profit to ₹142 crore for the first quarter of FY27, compared with ₹165 crore in the April-June quarter of the previous fiscal.

The profit attributable to owners of the parent stood at ₹142 crore during the quarter.

The company said elev-

Q1 performance (in ₹ cr)

	Q1FY26	Q1FY27	y-o-y % change
Revenue from operations	1,498	1,507	27
Net profit	165	142	-14

ated gas costs due to the West Asia crisis, an increase in the APM gas price ceiling and currency depreciation pushed natural gas procurement costs up 39 per cent y-o-y.

It added that it adopted a calibrated approach to pass on the higher gas costs to consumers to sustain volume growth.

Adani Total Gas operates in a single business segment, which includes the sale and distribution of natural gas. The company's operations are focused on providing natural gas distribution services across its operating areas.

COMPANY RESULTS

The company's revenue from operations, however, increased 27 per cent y-o-y to ₹1,907 crore during the period.

On a standalone basis, the

company reported a 13 per cent y-o-y increase in gas sales volume to 303 million standard cubic metres , driven by an 18 per cent rise in CNG volumes and a 4 per cent increase in PNG volumes.

Standalone revenue rose 27 per cent to ₹1,910 crore, while EBITDA declined 7 per cent to ₹281 crore.

During the quarter, Adani Total Gas expanded its CNG network to 707 stations by adding five new outlets and increased its PNG household connections to about 11.41 lakh after adding 38,243 new homes.

Its EV charging network also expanded to 5,306 charging points across 26 States and Union Territories.

Shares of Adani Total Gas closed 1.87 per cent lower at ₹699.35 on the BSE on Tuesday.

Adani Energy Solutions consolidated profit jumps 124% to ₹1,149 crore

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad

Adani Energy Solutions Ltd, one of India's integrated power infrastructure companies with operations spanning electricity transmission, distribution, smart metering and energy solutions, reported a 124 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) increase in consolidated profit after tax (PAT) to ₹1,149 crore in the first quarter of FY27.

The company's revenues from operations rose 42 per cent y-o-y to ₹9,711 crore during the quarter.

STRONG PERFORMANCE

The growth was driven by strong performance across its key businesses, including a 52 per cent increase in the transmission segment, 47 per cent growth in distribution, 210 per cent rise in smart metering and 812 per cent growth in the energy solutions platform.



Revenue from operations for the quarter ended June 30, 2026 stood at ₹9,837.82 crore before accounting for regulatory adjustments.

After considering the surplus/recovery of regulatory asset charge for past years, the reported revenue from operations stood at ₹9,711.08 crore.

The company had reported revenue from operations of ₹6,819.28 crore in the corresponding quarter of the previous year.

Adani Energy Solutions operates across multiple segments, including power transmission, distribution, smart metering, energy solutions platform and EPC contracts.

Maruti Suzuki to increase prices by up to ₹30,000

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Maruti Suzuki India on Tuesday said it will hike prices of its vehicles across models by up to ₹30,000 from August to partially offset the sustained increase in input costs. The exact quantum of change will vary from model to model, Maruti Suzuki India said in a regulatory filing.

The increase in prices will come into effect from August 2026.

"For the past few months, the company has been making continuous efforts to mitigate the cost impact to the extent possible through cost reduction measures," it added.

However, with inflationary pressure at elevated levels and the adverse cost environment continuing, the company said it is constrained to pass on a portion of the increased costs to the market, while continuing to ensure that the impact on customers is kept to the minimum extent possible.

Ashok Leyland bets on AI to improve services

Our Bureau
Chennai

The quieter but equally consequential change within Ashok Leyland is the deepening integration of artificial intelligence (AI) into its operations and products.

The company's Uptime Solution Centre, which uses live diagnostics and predictive maintenance algorithms to monitor over 170,000 connected vehicles in the field, has matured into a sophisticated operation that measurably improves fleet availability for our customers.

DRIVE EFFICIENCY

The connected vehicle data we gather — processing close to a terabyte of data every day across more than 25 million kilometres of tracked vehicle operation — feeds directly into product development, creating a closed loop between what operators experience on the road and what our engineers design at the drawing board, said Dheeraj Hinduja, Chairman, Ashok Leyland, in the



TVS Motor plans price hike to offset inflation

Our Bureau
Chennai

TVS Motor Company has indicated that it will consider price increases in the second quarter to offset rising commodity costs, while continuing to invest in its super premium Norton brand.

Speaking during the earnings call on Tuesday, the company's Director and Chief Executive Officer, KN Radhakrishnan, said the sharp increase in steel, aluminium and petroleum-linked input costs during the June quarter, triggered by the West Asia conflict, had put pressure on margins.

"There was a sharp upward trend in commodity prices during Q1. We are closely watching the situation and will appropriately look at opportunities to rightly give price increases," he said. Cost optimisation and management scale benefits will continue in the second quarter.

NORTON INVESTMENT

TVS also reaffirmed its long-term commitment to the super premium motorcycle segment through Norton Motorcycles, saying it has invested about ₹2,500 crore over the past four to five years in reviving and expanding the British brand.

The company is preparing to launch four new Norton motorcycles across global markets, including the UK, Europe, the US and India, he said, without giving information on the launch date.

The upcoming Norton range will include motorcycles across superbike, naked sport, adventure and sport-touring segments, he added.

The go-to-market strategy would combine dedicated premium dealerships with select multi-brand outlets depending on the country, while expanding the distri-

bution network in phases, said Radhakrishnan.

The Norton strategy complements TVS Motor's broader premiumisation plans, alongside brands such as Apache and Ronin, which the company expects will support both revenue growth and profitability over the medium term.

In June, Norton Motorcycles marked the roll-out of the first Atlas models at TVS Motor Company's Hosur manufacturing facility in India.

CAPACITY EXPANSION

TVS is investing around ₹3,500 crore this fiscal towards new product development and capacity expansion, including premium motorcycles, electric vehicles and manufacturing capacity.

TVS would increase its annual two-wheeler manufacturing capacity to 8.3 million units from the current 6.8 million units by the fourth quarter of the current financial year. The company is also expanding annual three-wheeler capacity from 2.5 lakh units to 4.2 lakh units, while scaling up electric vehicle production, said Radhakrishnan.

TVS is raising its monthly electric scooter production capacity from 40,000 units to over 50,000 units, while electric three-wheeler capacity is being increased from 20,000 units to around 30,000 units a month, he said.



Dheeraj Hinduja, Ashok Leyland Chairman

company's FY26 annual report.

Hinduja said the company is deploying AI across manufacturing quality control, supply chain optimisation, and after-sales response, achieving a fourfold reduction in processing costs in certain workflows and meaningfully faster response times across our service network.

Electrification is gaining traction in buses and urban logistics, while alternative fuels such as LNG and hydrogen are becoming more relevant for long-haul applications. AI is no longer an experimental technology in our sector — it has become a foundational operating tool, he said.

PLI schemes attract ₹2.4 lakh cr, create over 14 lakh jobs till March

EXPORT SURGE. Solar modules, pharma led investments as exports cross ₹15.2 lakh cr

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The government’s flagship Production Linked Incentive (PLI) schemes have attracted investments of more than ₹2.4 lakh crore, generated over 14.15 lakh jobs and enabled cumulative exports worth over ₹15.2 lakh crore till March 31, 2026, highlighting the growing impact of the programme on India’s manufacturing and export sectors.

In a written reply to the Lok Sabha on Tuesday, Minister of State for Commerce and Industry Jitin Prasada said the PLI schemes, covering 14 manufacturing sectors with a total approved outlay of ₹1.91 lakh crore, had resulted in actual investments of ₹2,40,138 crore.

“The implementation of the PLI schemes is reviewed periodically by the empowered group of secretaries (EGoS), chaired by the Cabinet Secretary, as well as by the respective administrative Ministries/Departments. Based on stakeholder feedback and implementation experience, modifications have

Sectoral impact		
Sectors	Cumulative investment till March 2026	Cumulative employment till March 2026 (₹ in crore)
Large-scale electronics manufacturing	20,580	1,69,249
IT Hardware 2.0	908	4,859
Bulk drugs	5,070	5,226
Manufacturing of medical devices	1,151	5,268
Pharmaceutical drugs	45,158	1,14,880
Telecom & networking products	5,278	33,610
Food products	9,207	3,29,200
Drones and drone components*	595	2,650
White goods	6,409	52,703
Automobiles & auto components	44,326	67,820
Advance chemistry cell battery	4,570	1,245
Textile products	8,117	33,427
Specialty steel	23,896	14,138
High efficiency solar PV modules	64,873	14,794
Total	2,40,138	8,49,069

* Note: Indirect employment generation of 5.66 lakh have been reported under 3 sectors (LSEM, IT Hardware & solar PV modules).

been carried out in certain Schemes, wherever required, to address implementation challenges and facilitate effective implementation,” Prasada said.

The high-efficiency solar PV modules sector has emerged as the biggest investment destination under the scheme, attracting ₹64,873 crore, accounting for more than a quarter of the total investments. It was

followed by pharmaceuticals with ₹45,158 crore, automobiles and auto components with ₹44,326 crore, specialty steel at ₹23,896 crore, and large-scale electronics manufacturing at ₹20,580 crore.

The schemes have generated 8.49 lakh direct jobs, while indirect employment of around 5.66 lakh has been reported under the large-scale electronics manufacturing, IT hardware and solar

PV module sectors, taking the total employment generated to more than 14.15 lakh.

DIRECT EMPLOYMENT

The food processing sector accounted for the highest direct employment at 3.29 lakh, followed by large-scale electronics manufacturing (1.69 lakh), pharmaceuticals (1.15 lakh), automobiles and auto components (67,820) and white goods (52,703).

The government said cumulative exports under the PLI schemes have risen from ₹4 lakh crore as of March 2024 to over ₹15.2 lakh crore by March 2026.

Highlighting sectoral outcomes, the government said mobile phone production has increased 2.4 times since the launch of the electronics PLI scheme, while imports have declined by 77 per cent.

Nearly 99.2 per cent of mobile phones used in India are now manufactured domestically. The pharmaceuticals scheme has recorded cumulative sales of ₹3.64 lakh crore and enabled domestic production of 1,931 products, including 191 bulk drugs manufactured in India for the first time.

WTO urges India to deepen reforms as New Delhi flags global trade barriers

Amiti Sen
New Delhi



Commerce Secretary
Rajesh Agrawal

The World Trade Organization (WTO) Secretariat has urged India to press ahead with reforms to lower trade costs, ease regulatory complexity and deepen its integration with the global economy, even as it aspires to increase its share of global merchandise exports to around 10 per cent by 2047 from 1.8 per cent in 2024 under the Viksit Bharat vision.

New Delhi maintains that rising geopolitical tensions and proliferating non-tariff barriers are increasingly limiting its export prospects, as the country’s eighth Trade Policy Review (TPR) began at the WTO on July 21.

“Sustaining the strong economic performance needed to reach the Viksit Bharat vision of a developed India by 2047 will require addressing structural challenges, including high trade costs, regulatory complexity, infrastructure gaps, and barriers to deeper global integration,” the WTO Secretariat noted in its report.

It added that export promotion was also emphasised in the Viksit Bharat vision, intended to help India sus-

tain high long-term growth and boost competitiveness. “Under this vision, India aims to increase its share of global merchandise exports from about 1.8 per cent in 2024 to around 10 per cent by 2047,” it noted.

EXTERNAL CHALLENGES

India’s trade performance in recent years has been impacted by a range of external challenges, the country noted in its own report.

“India is also facing an increased use of non-tariff measures by some trading partners, including complex standards, conformity assessment procedures and regulatory requirements. These have resulted in constrained market access for Indian industry in foreign markets,” the report said.

Events such as global supply chain disruptions arising from geopolitical tensions, pandemic, climate-related

events, and export controls by some countries have adversely affected the availability and cost of critical inputs. In addition, issues of excess capacity and overproduction in certain sectors have led to trade distortions and price fluctuations in international markets, India’s report added.

“Despite a challenging global environment, India has remained the world’s fastest-growing major economy, achieved record exports, accelerated digital transformation, strengthened innovation, improved the ease of doing business, and expanded opportunities for trade and investment.

POLICY FRAMEWORK

However, it noted that India’s policy framework continues to rely on relatively high tariffs, import and export controls, state trading enterprises and extensive budgetary support programmes, particularly for foodgrains and fertilizers. While acknowledging that these policies support food security and rural livelihoods, the report suggested they continue to shape India’s trade regime.

Looking ahead, the Secretariat noted India’s GDP growth was projected at 6.8-7.2 per cent in FY2027-28 but said sustaining such growth over the longer term would require addressing structural constraints such as high trade costs, infrastructure gaps, regulatory complexity and barriers to deeper global integration.

‘Chinese participation in power projects will enhance competition’

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

The government has said that allowing Chinese companies to participate in power projects will enhance competition, promote price stability and address supply constraints.

The government has recently allowed four entities, having substantial ownership by entities from land border sharing countries, for participation in India in the procurement bids for power projects for two years with effect from June 24, subject to such entities complying with the prescribed domestic content requirements, said Minister of State for Power Shripad Naik.

“This would enhance competition, promote price stability, and address supply constraints, while supporting the objectives of the Atmanirbhar Bharat initiative,” Naik said in response to a question in the Rajya Sabha on Monday.

The Minister emphasised that products manufactured at such India-based facilities are subject to mandatory BIS/IS testing and certification by designated certifying agencies. In addition, compliance with applicable Indian cyber security guidelines and standards, including mandatory cyber security testing, as may be required.

“Accordingly, adequate

safeguards are in place to address potential national security concerns without imposing a blanket exclusion on such entities, thereby ensuring that security interests are protected while facilitating competitive procurement,” the Minister assured the House.

TWO-YEAR EXEMPTION

The issue relates to the government granting a two-year exemption under the Public Procurement Order to four China-linked power equipment manufacturers with manufacturing operations in India.

The exemption enables these companies — TBEA Energy India, Nanjing Electric India, New Northeast Electric India, and Taikai Electric (India) — to participate in public sector procurement for critical power infrastructure projects, particularly in high-voltage transformers and gas insulated switchgear, where domestic manufacturing capacity remains constrained.

Sources said that the Power Ministry sought the exemption to avoid project delays while indigenous capabilities continue to scale. For companies across the power, transmission & distribution, renewable energy, industrial automation and infrastructure sectors, the development signals heightened competitive intensity in grid equipment procurement over the next two years.

Value of rupee market-determined with no specific level or band: FM

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Tuesday said the rupee’s value against the US dollar is market-determined and there is no target or specific band for the domestic currency.

“The government closely tracks the trends in key economic parameters, including exchange rate movements, along with their implications for economic growth and fiscal stability. These issues are discussed at various fora at various levels of the government,” she said in a written reply in the Rajya Sabha.

On Tuesday, the rupee pared initial losses and settled 12 paise higher at 96.24. Traders attribute the recovery to RBI’s intervention. Sitharaman said the value of the rupee is market-determined, with no target or specific level or band, and RBI regularly

monitors the foreign exchange market and intervenes in situations of excess volatility.

Further, the RBI monitors key developments across the globe which may have an impact on the USD-INR exchange rate, she said.

Various measures have been taken by RBI to boost forex inflows, which in turn may ease the pressure on rupee. These include amendment to the external commercial borrowings (ECB) framework in February 2026 through expansion of eligible borrower and recognised lender base, rationalisation of borrowing limits and restrictions on average maturity period.

Besides, on June 5, RBI announced a slew of measures to boost inflow of foreign capital including raising limits for investment by non-resident Indians and overseas citizens of India in equity instruments traded on the stock market without SEBI registration.



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Urea trouble

Deep-rooted reforms needed to woo private sector

When geopolitical instability sets in, India often faces disruption not just to its energy supplies but also to food, because of its high import dependence for fertilizers. This explains why successive governments have devised incentive schemes to promote domestic urea production, despite patchy results. The New Investment Policy in 2014 created fresh urea capacity of about 7.6 million tonnes — yet a 10 million tonne deficit remains. The National Investment Policy 2026 (NIP 2026) announced recently aims to bridge this gap.



This policy targets eight to nine new gas-based plants, and tries to incentivise urea production by addressing the shortcomings of the earlier scheme. However, it is moot if the private sector will take the bait. Urea remains one of the most complex industries to operate in, with regulatory controls dictating every aspect of operations from feedstock sourcing to branding to distribution and pricing. The primary challenge for any enterprise looking to set up a new urea plant is the fixed selling price of urea, which at about ₹5400/tonne, is less than a tenth of the production costs. Therefore, viability of operations is decided by the extent to which subsidies bridge this deficit. Here, NIP 2026's design appears superior to the previous scheme.

It promises investors in new urea plants a minimum return on equity of 12-16 per cent. Under the earlier scheme, subsidy was pegged to the import parity price of urea, with a floor of \$305 and a ceiling of \$335 per tonne — with escalations allowed for spikes in global gas prices. This approach made no provision for escalations in fixed project costs or rupee depreciation. NIP 2026 however, factors in both fixed and variable costs of production for calculating the assured return on equity. It also promises to protect producers from exchange rate swings while they build new capacity, by offering rupee reimbursement of foreign exchange costs at the end of the first four years. Allowing return on equity within a range of 12-16 per cent can help accommodate overshoots due to inflation, interest rates or currency risks.

NIP 2026 is not without its shortcomings. Allowing pass-through of virtually all costs, with guaranteed returns, is not a great idea. It provides no incentive for a unit to lower costs or improve efficiency. We have been through this before. The Retention Pricing Scheme that ran between 1977 and 2003 before it was shelved encouraged gold-plating of capacities, leading to spiralling production costs. While NIP 2026 may address the import dependence on urea, Indian producers will still remain import dependent for natural gas to power their plants. The Centre cannot do much, except to diversify feedstock sources. The many flip-flops on urea policy over the years have made private industry wary of undertaking any new projects; public sector units now dominate capacity. Deep-rooted reforms in urea pricing and distribution are needed to woo private players back.

POCKET

RAVIKANTH



NISHANT SAHDEV

India has ₹7,280 crore on the table in incentives for companies willing to build it a rare-earth magnet industry from scratch. In late June, for the second time, it pushed back the deadline for them to bid — because the bidders were not ready to say yes.

A postponed deadline looks like paperwork. It is, in fact, one of the most revealing things to happen in India's critical-minerals push all year. The state has done the hard work, and builders are still hesitating. When money on this scale goes unclaimed, the issue is sitting somewhere the money cannot reach.

That somewhere is the science of the magnet itself.

Start with what is at stake. India buys 85-90 per cent of its rare-earth magnets from abroad, almost all of it from China. When Beijing tightened rare-earth exports through 2025, carmakers around the world had to slow or halt production for want of a part smaller than your fist, and the price of neodymium outside China shot up several-fold. Those curbs are only paused, not lifted — the pause on the harshest measures runs out in November.

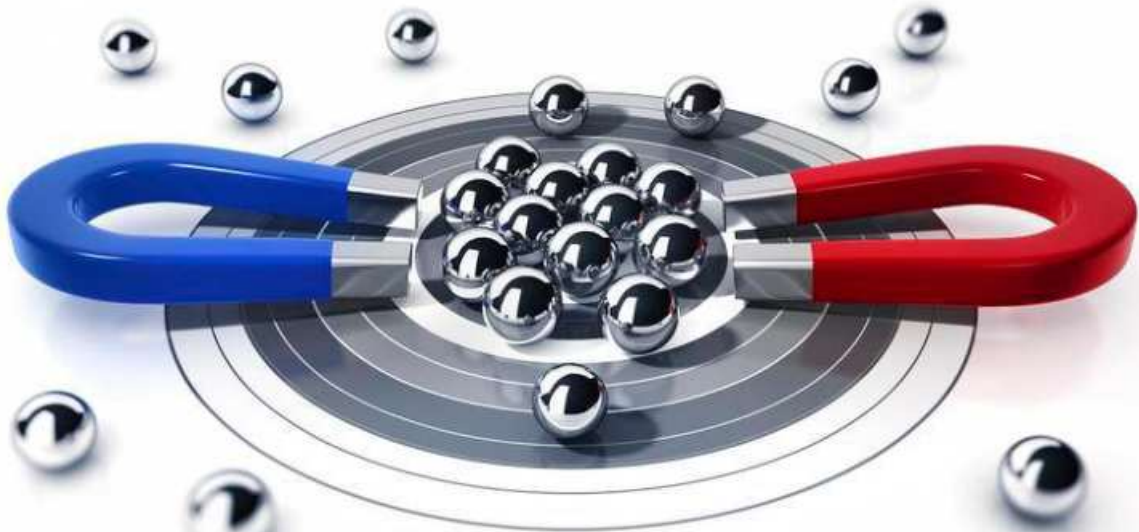
When the restrictions first hit, India's magnet stock was reckoned to last two to three weeks. That thin buffer is all that stands between the country's factories and a standstill.

India's answer has not been small. A ₹34,300-crore National Critical Minerals Mission. The ₹7,280-crore magnet scheme, spread across five producers, to build 6,000 tonnes of capacity a year. Rare-earth corridors in four States in this year's Budget, and a pilot magnet plant at Hyderabad. On paper, a full chain from mine to magnet. But the plan is aimed at the wrong target. It treats the problem as money and ore. It is neither.

China grasped the real prize long ago. Deng Xiaoping's much-quoted line from 1992 — that the Middle East had oil, and China had rare earths — is usually read as a boast about deposits. It was cleverer than that. China did not just sit on the ore; it spent three decades learning what to do with it, soaking up the pollution and the failures that richer countries were happy to send elsewhere.

The result shows up in one lopsided fact. China digs up about 60 per cent of the world's magnet-grade rare earths — a lot, but not a stranglehold. It does about 91 per cent of the refining that turns them into usable material.

The bottleneck, in other words, is not the digging. It is the refining and the making. Rare earths, despite the name, are not rare in the ground. What is rare is knowing how to tame them.



GETTY IMAGES

Coming to grips with rare earths

REFINED TECH. China doesn't dominate rare earths because it owns the mines. It dominates because it spent 30 years learning to refine them — a lead money alone can't close

Why can nothing cheaper stand in? Because of how magnetism actually works. Think of two kinds of magnet: a fair-weather one and a committed one. Ordinary iron is fair-weather — magnetise it and it loses its grip easily, especially when heated or knocked. Neodymium is committed.

Its magnetism sits deep and shielded inside the atom, which lets it hold its direction fiercely. That is what makes a rare-earth magnet both powerful and stubborn.

And for the hottest jobs — the motor of an electric car, a wind turbine, a guided missile — even neodymium needs help, so a pinch of two scarcer cousins, dysprosium and terbium, is added to stop the magnet losing its nerve when things get hot. Those were the very elements China restricted first. You cannot simply swap in something common and abundant. The strength is built into the atom.

Here is the part almost every debate on this misses. A magnet is less a material than an arrangement. Inside it sit millions of tiny magnetic grains, and the whole thing works only when nearly all of them are combed to point the same way — a crowd all facing one direction. Melt the same atoms and let them cool at random, and the grains point every

Even with the right elements in hand, turning them into a finished magnet takes a dozen-plus exacting steps

which way and cancel out. You get a paperweight, not a magnet. So what a magnet-maker really sells is not neodymium. It is ordered. And order is the most expensive thing in nature, because the world constantly tends towards mess, and holding it in neat formation takes relentless effort. India is not trying to buy metal. It is trying to buy orders, made perfectly, again and again.

OVER A DOZEN EXACTING STEPS

This is what the bidders mean when they say they need "technology access". Even with the right elements in hand, turning them into a finished magnet takes a dozen-plus exacting steps — separating the elements, grinding the material to a powder finer than flour, pressing that powder in a magnetic field so the grains line up, baking it in a furnace above a thousand degrees, machining, coating and finally magnetising it. Each step quietly loses a little quality, like a relay in which any runner can drop the baton.

Getting the powder pure, keeping stray air out, timing the furnace just so — none of this comes written in a manual you can buy. It is know-how, earned the hard way through spoiled batches. China's edge is not that it built the furnaces first. It is that it has been getting it wrong inside them for 30 years, and learning.

That word — learning — is where the economics bites. Making things has an iron rule: costs fall only as you build up experience, batch after batch, mistake after fixed mistake. You cannot pay your way past that curve; you can only climb

it, one failed run at a time. It is like pottery — the first hundred pots crack no matter how big the grant. A scheme that pays out per tonne assumes the tonnes are good. Early tonnes rarely are. If half your magnets flunk quality while the furnace learns, your true cost per usable magnet is double what the spreadsheet says — and that gap, not the headline figure, is what a careful bidder is staring at.

India's own numbers show the distance. IREL, the state producer that has run this work since 1963, currently makes only about 400 to 500 tonnes a year of the key refined material — enough to feed roughly a quarter of the new scheme's target. It hopes to reach 10,000 tonnes by 2027. The gap between that promise and today is the whole task.

None of this is a case for giving up. It is a case for spending where the real difficulty lies. Pay for know-how — the chemistry, the furnace craft, and the people who own it — as seriously as the mines, because that, not ore, is the scarce thing. Lean hard on recycling: India imports its magnets already tucked inside motors, drives and speakers, which means its richest rare-earth mine may turn out to be its own scrapyard — and pulling magnets out of dead machines skips the hardest steps entirely. And use the friends India has — its mineral partnerships with Australia, Japan and the West — to borrow skill while its own furnaces learn.

The writer is a physicist at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill and a tech columnist

Stop asking whether the world has too many people

There's no ideal population size. The goal shouldn't be to increase or reduce population but to build demographic resilience

Atanu Biswas

Every few years, the world returns to the same old argument. One side warns that humanity is growing beyond the planet's limits. The other worries about empty cradles, ageing societies and shrinking workforces. Both arguments contain a grain of truth, but they both overlook the larger context. The real story is not a single global population crisis. It's a world moving in different demographic directions at once.

The global population has crossed 8.3 billion and is still rising. But beneath that headline lies a remarkable shift. The average woman today has about 2.3 children — less than half the global fertility rate of the 1950s. Per different estimates, nearly two-thirds of the world's people now live in countries where fertility has fallen below the replacement level of 2.1 births per woman. Once fertility remains below that threshold for long enough, populations begin to age and decline.

East Asia illustrates the trend dramatically. South Korea's fertility rate has fallen to around 0.72, the lowest ever recorded for a major economy. China, after decades of limiting births, is now urging couples to have more children. Japan has become a symbol of demographic ageing, with shrinking

schools, deserted villages and an expanding elderly population. Much of Europe faces similar challenges, while even the US now records births below replacement level.

The picture is very different elsewhere. Across much of Sub-Saharan Africa, populations continue to grow rapidly. India, despite fertility nearing replacement level, remains so populous because of the momentum created by earlier decades of high birth rates. However, southern States such as Kerala and Tamil Nadu already have fertility rates comparable to Europe, while some northern States still have relatively higher fertility. In other words, the global demographic paradox exists within India as well.

FEARS OF OVERPOPULATION

For decades, population debates were dominated by fears of overpopulation. Influential books such as *The Population Bomb* predicted global catastrophe, prompting governments to launch population-control programmes. Many people came to believe that fewer births automatically meant a better future. Reality has proved far more complex.

Fertility usually declines as countries become healthier, wealthier and better educated. Women pursue higher education and careers, infant mortality falls, urban housing becomes expensive, and raising children costs more. Smaller



REAL ISSUE. The world is moving in different demographic directions at once

families are often signs of development rather than decline.

Yet success brings new problems. Ageing societies have fewer workers supporting more retirees. Pension systems come under pressure, healthcare costs rise, labour shortages become chronic and economic growth slows. Governments have responded with generous incentives, subsidised childcare and extended parental leave, but to little effect. Government bonuses are not as important as economic security, affordable housing and confidence in the future as it pertains to decisions about having children.

Meanwhile, countries with rapidly growing populations face different pressures — overcrowded schools, youth unemployment, housing

shortages, and increasing stress on food and water resources.

Perhaps the greatest misconception is that there is an ideal population size. There is not. What matters is not simply how many people a country has, but their age structure, health, education, productivity, and opportunities. A rapidly ageing society and a rapidly growing one require entirely different policy responses. Nor is population alone responsible for environmental pressure. Consumption matters just as much. A child born in a wealthy country will typically consume far more energy and natural resources over a lifetime than one born in a poorer nation. Concentrating on population numbers alone ignores these huge inequalities.

The goal, therefore, shouldn't be to increase or reduce population indiscriminately but to build demographic resilience. That means making parenthood affordable where people want children, embracing well-managed immigration where labour shortages threaten growth, using automation to offset shrinking workforces, and ensuring universal education, healthcare, and reproductive choice where populations are still expanding. That would reduce fertility rates.

The writer is Professor of Statistics, Indian Statistical Institute, Kolkata

✉ **LETTERS TO EDITOR** Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to 'Letters to the Editor', The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Review LTCG

This refers to 'No proposal now to scrap LTCG on equity transactions: FinMin' (July 21). The government's decision appears ill-timed when FPI outflows continue and the rupee remains under pressure against the dollar. At the same time, the authorities have been encouraging foreign capital through the special FCNR(B) scheme, including a dollar-rupee swap facility and temporary CRR/SLR exemptions. With 3-5 year domestic fixed deposit rates of 6-6.5 per cent now broadly matching FCNR(B) deposit rates, the

incentives appear skewed. Further, the Indian stock market has been among the weakest-performing major markets in 2026. In such an environment, retaining the LTCG tax does little to encourage long-term investment in equities.

Srinivasan Velamur
Arizona, US

ISRO's talent exodus

The success of Skyroot Aerospace on the launch pad is undoubtedly a milestone. At the same time, the high attrition rate at ISRO is a challenge that the Government needs to

address effectively. The exodus of experienced scientists and engineers from ISRO to private firms, largely driven by better pay packages and faster career progression, could affect the organisation's ability to undertake complex and mission-critical projects.

S Lakshminarayanan
Ko-Puvanur, TN

Vikram-1 launch

Apropos 'Will Vikram-1 be a commercial success?' (July 21), Skyroot Aerospace's successful Vikram-1 launch is a proud milestone

moment for India. By joining the US and China in the private orbital launch club, India has showcased the commercial potential of its space sector and the benefits of policy support for private enterprise. Extending similar reforms to nuclear power can boost energy security.

PV Prakash
Mumbai

Spain's triumph

Apropos 'Felicidades, Espana' (July 21), Spain's World Cup triumph deserves applause for more than one reason. The coach, Luis de la Fuente

shaped this side through years of coaching younger national teams before getting to helm the senior national team. This continuity produced a disciplined team which conceded very few chances throughout the world cup campaign. Ferran Torres may have scored the winning goal but it was a complete team effort. Clean passing, disciplined defending and patient movement became the team's trademarks from the opening match to the finals.

Bal Govind
Noida

Trump’s China gamble

Mid-term polls: Trump is playing all his cards

Sridhar Krishnaswami

With three months to go for the mid-term elections, there is every indication that US President Donald Trump is leaving no stone unturned to make sure his Republican Party continues to hold the majority status in Congress. There are indications of the House of Representatives, where the Grand Old Party has a slender lead, flipping. Increasingly there are signs that the Senate could also be within the striking distance of Democrats.

And the White House knows well that if Democrats even control one of the two Houses, Trump’s legislative agenda is in big trouble. Already, some Republicans are flagging the concern that there is only one reason why Democrats want to capture power on Capitol Hill: to start the impeachment process all over again.

In the run-up to the November 3 showdown, Trump has posted impressive victories in the primaries, making sure to humble candidates that did not have his backing. Some within the GOP have felt uncomfortable in seeing veteran law makers being shown the door, and on the short term implications of their negative votes in the House and Senate until a new Congress gets sworn in January 2027.

In broader perspective, Trump has had his way in re-districting, at least at the States level, but was nationally perhaps blunted by the counter-gerrymandering efforts of the Democrats especially in large states like California.

One perception is that the Republicans may have an advantage of about 10 seats in the House — if all votes head their way — but whether that’s enough to get over the challenge of the Democrats is the question. Republican red states have also tried their hand at limiting mail-in voting, tightening voter ID laws, ridding the same day voter registration procedures, shortening early voting and curbing ballot box drops. And in the name of Election Integrity, there have been attempts to restrict supply of hot food in the vicinity of polling centres and even distribution of water to people standing in line to vote.

CHINA CARD
Still unsure if all these measures are enough to push the GOP over the line in the mid-terms, Trump pulled his ace election security card in his unprecedented



TRUMP. Mid-term worries REUTERS

national prime time address last week alleging China interfered with the 2020 elections and that intelligence documents that was subsequently thrown open for public scrutiny revealed “shocking vulnerabilities”.

In his address Trump once again whipped up his long held claims of unreliability of American elections but falling well short of proving any of the votes were either altered or manipulated. Beijing rubbished allegations of its interference as “totally fabricated and a malicious smear” with a Foreign Ministry Spokesperson adding that Trump’s allegations “have long been proven to be sheer nonsense”.

Trump has long dissed his own intelligence community and in the current context asserted that it deliberately suppressed the extent of Beijing’s activities. But what has been pointed out is that intelligence in 2021 had come to the conclusion that no foreign actor had attempted or succeeded in altering “any technical aspect” of the 2020 vote. And this assessment was done by John Ratcliffe, the then Director of National Intelligence and presently heading the Central Intelligence Agency. Further it is being pointed out that the data sourced by China is out there in public domain and available for purchase and done so routinely by political consultants. The bottom line: the excitement of Beijing accessing some 220 million voter files amounted to nothing other than academic curiosity.

Trump’s hardcore base may be jubilant at the so-called revelations, but not the sober minded Republicans who are apprehensive of a drift back to the debunked notions of the 2020 vote instead of paying attention to the issues facing America today — high prices, affordable housing and ways to end a war that a few know why it even began.

The writer is a senior journalist who has reported from Washington DC on North America and United Nations

CAPITAL IDEAS.



RICHA MISHRA

Remember the “9 PM, 9 Minutes” event on April 5, 2020? It was the ultimate real-time test of India’s grid infrastructure, when millions of citizens turned off their home lights simultaneously. What it did was that it created an artificial shockwave that showed exactly why India needs fast, automated energy storage systems.

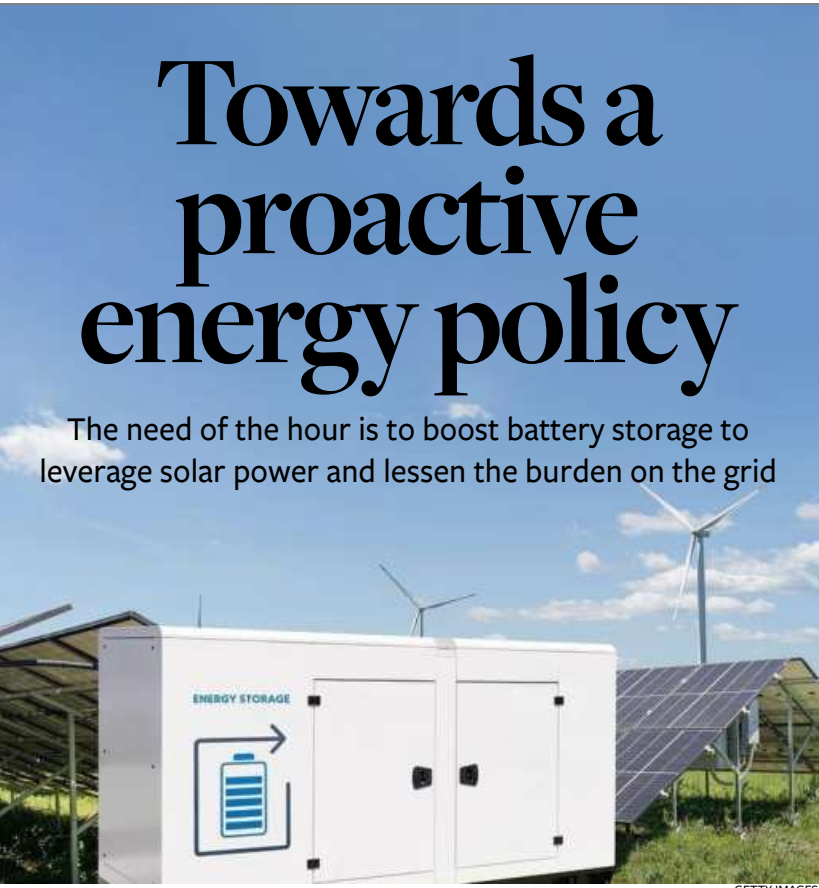
Before the pandemic, India’s energy vulnerability was mostly viewed through the lens of fuel shortages or physical equipment failures. The pandemic changed this by introducing three immediate operational shocks that proved the grid’s inability to function smoothly without flexible, fast storage solutions.

Then came geopolitical conflicts. When geopolitical conflicts disrupt the flow of oil and LNG, the economic and operational impacts on countries including India are immediate and systemic. This chokehold directly triggers a cascading crisis across India’s domestic energy infrastructure, exposing its lack of structural shock absorbers.

India relies on imported West Asian LNG to fuel 24,000 MW of gas-fired power infrastructure. A supply halt deactivates these vital peaking plants, which grid operators depend on to manage sharp evening demand spikes. Deprived of gas, utilities must either over-stress ageing coal fleets or enforce rolling blackouts.

The deficit in gas infrastructure shifts the entire burden of real-time frequency stabilisation onto India’s overstretched hydroelectric fleet. This operational strain mirrors the vulnerabilities exposed during the pandemic, leaving grid operators with virtually zero technical cushion to absorb unexpected supply-demand imbalances.

INFRASTRUCTURE DEFICIT
This deep infrastructural deficit forces national load dispatch centres to make critical operational compromises. They must either aggressively throttle back variable solar and wind generation — wasting clean energy through forced curtailment — or allow the grid’s operational frequency to fluctuate



GETTY IMAGES

The need of the hour is to boost battery storage to leverage solar power and lessen the burden on the grid

dangerously, risking localised blackouts and equipment damage from unmanageable frequency swings.

While the government consistently pledges to expand oil, gas, and green energy storage capacities, critics argue that these initiatives are perpetually reactive to external shocks. Instead of proactively building long-term, structural insulation against geopolitical and operational crises, policymakers routinely wait for a market disruption to trigger emergency infrastructure expansions.

A working paper, released in July, by the Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister (EAC-PM), “The Duck and The Camel: Tracing the Net Load on the Indian Power Grid”, authored by Sanjeev Sanyal and Satvil Dev, argues that managing demand and price volatility requires storing electricity during times of abundance for release

India’s primary energy challenge has shifted from overall generation capacity to optimising the timing and flexibility of power generation

during shortages. The paper demonstrates that India’s primary energy challenge has shifted from overall generation capacity to optimising the timing and flexibility of power generation.

It argues that three market signals confirm the diagnosis:

(a) the intra-day price spread between the solar hours and the non-solar hours has widened to a peak-to-trough ratio approaching nine, held back only by the market’s price ceiling;

(b) the grid’s failures to meet demand rise overwhelmingly in the non-solar hours, relative to solar hours;

(c) solar energy is curtailed in volume because it cannot be used at the moment it is produced. The curtailment figures are striking: the average per day solar curtailment for May 2026 was equivalent to throwing away electricity that could have powered more than a quarter of Delhi for an entire day.

STORING ENERGY

The paper points out that growth in solar, without concomitant and adequate growth in storage and without implementation of other net load smoothening policies, will add to grid stress. This is an argument which has

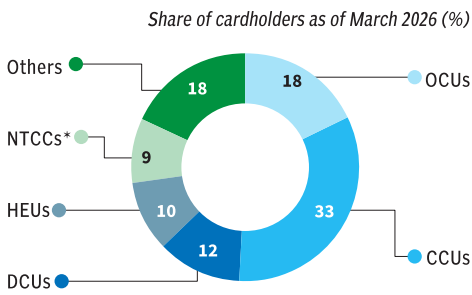
STATISTALK.

Compiled Nishanth Gopalakrishnan | Graphic Visveswaran V

Decoding the Indian cardholder ecosystem

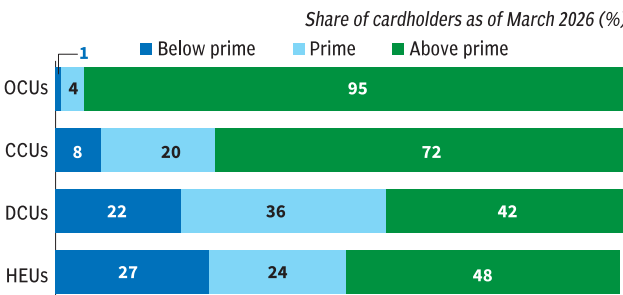
A recent white paper by TransUnion CIBIL classifies credit card users into four personae namely, occasional card users (OCUs), card-centric users (CCUs), diversified credit users (DCUs) and high exposure users (HEUs). OCUs are the least aggressive with low utilisation of credit limit (<10%) and cards are their primary exposure to unsecured credit. CCUs use cards for liquidity and have moderate utilisation (10-75%). DCUs have multiple consumption-based loans alongside cards with moderate utilisation. DCUs with high utilisation (>75%) and multiple cards graduate into HEUs. Trends exhibited by these personae are captured in the charts

Composition of the personae



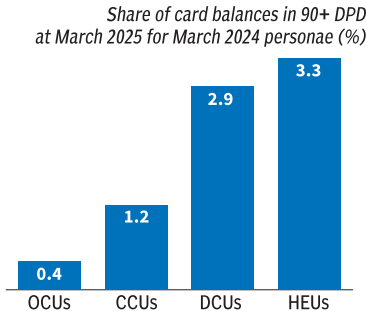
*new to credit card; <12 months since acquiring first card

DCU and HEU cohorts have relatively high risk card users...

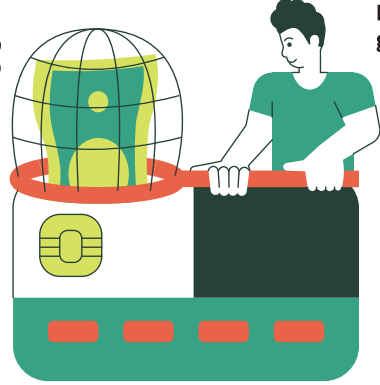


Based on credit score, below prime = 300-750; prime = 751-810; above prime = 811-900

...and are the most delinquent

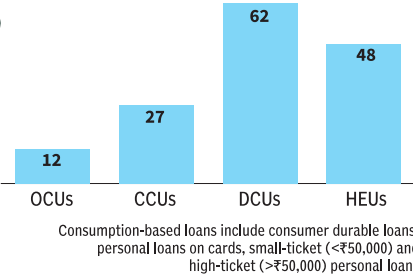


DPD - days past due
Source: Beyond the Swipe - June 2026 by TransUnion CIBIL



DCUs and HEUs demonstrate greater credit demand

Share of card users as of March 2024 who availed a new consumption-based loan by March 2025 (%)



Consumption-based loans include consumer durable loans, personal loans on cards, small-ticket (<₹50,000) and high-ticket (>₹50,000) personal loans

thehindubusinessline.

TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

July 22, 2006

‘Inflation rate of 4.6% tolerable’

The Finance Minister, Mr P. Chidambaram, said on Friday that an annual inflation rate of 4.68 per cent, as per the latest estimate for the week ended July 8, was “tolerable”. For a country that is growing at 8 per cent for the third year in succession, it is inconceivable that there won’t be some inflation,” Mr Chidambaram told reporters after a meeting with public sector bank chiefs.

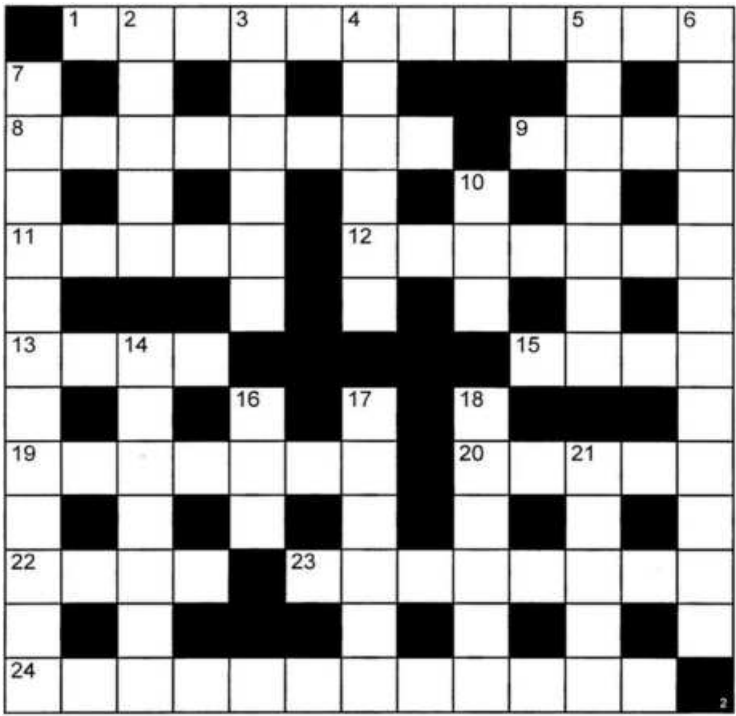
R-ADAG to invest Rs 61,500 cr in Orissa

The Reliance ADA Group on Friday announced its plan to invest Rs 61,500 crore in Orissa to set up a 12,000 MW mega thermal power plant, a health city and an institute of higher learning in information technology. The announcement was made by the Chairman of the Group, Mr Anil Ambani, after he held detailed discussions with the Chief Minister, Mr Naveen Patnaik.

Banks allowed to raise long-term capital in foreign currency

In a move to help banks shore up their capital to meet Basle II norms, the Reserve Bank of India on Friday allowed banks to raise long-term capital in foreign capital. Banks can raise funds through innovative perpetual debt instruments that can be part of Tier I capital.

BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2698



EASY

ACROSS

- Proceeding from divine providence (12)
- Treating, dealing with (8)
- A clenched hand (4)
- The elk in America (5)
- Unimportant, trifling (7)
- Not difficult (4)
- A sign on musical stave (4)
- Weighty, bulky (7)
- Unadorned (5)
- Move through water (4)
- Sweet confection of egg white, sugar (8)
- Act of pronouncing unfit for use (12)

DOWN

- Musical movement with recurring subject (5)
- Soft material (6)
- Mean, signify (6)
- Put first letters of name to (7)
- One’s pinkie (6,6)
- Compositions for quartets, trios etc (7,5)
- False hairpiece (3)
- Period of sitting (7)
- Make fast; mend (3)
- Lower oneself in dignity (6)
- A short, quick run (6)
- Aggressive behaviour (5)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

- By God’s will, furnish a translation of Latin (12)
- Dealing with the cards one has been dealt with the fish (8)
- Duke seen if put back on the street (4)
- Like the elk, it sounds like a cow to the English (5)
- Piffling, the amount of it rival can produce (7)
- Simple as it is, they half get around it (4)
- It could be treble the character a musician will recognise (4)
- Huge as it is, I have to follow the service (7)
- It is as clear as the Russian steppe (5)
- In the which, one knows – how to crawl? (4)
- There may be the urge in me to make it with egg-white and sugar (8)
- Pronouncement of guilt cannot do mine out of it (12)

DOWN

- Last sonata movement to be arranged by donor (5)
- In novel veterinary treatment it covers the antlers (6)
- It will signify the need to change (6)
- It stands for name one twice confuses with Latin (7)
- Pinkie felt it moving : hang about outside! (6,6)
- In Summer, Bach may have been in charge of such composition (7,5)
- Scold one for one’s transformation (3)
- Is among the beaks put up at a sitting (7)
- If in such a predicament, one may have to mend it (3)
- Emend a form that could lower one’s reputation (6)
- Perhaps trips around the North in a quick run (6)
- Have trouble brewing a grog such as this? (5)

SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2697

ACROSS 1. Scotch 8. Spoil 9. Sanctum 11. Runabout 12. Stole 15. Nags 16. Ate 17. Peel 19. Messy 21. Quandary 24. Sandals 25. Idols 26. Dodder

DOWN 2. Craft 3. Ticklish 4. Hour 5. Essay 6. So-so 7. Blot 10. Muleteers 12. Sink 13. Splendid 14. Play 18. Odist 20. Salve 21. Quid 22. Agog 23. Yard

QUICKLY.

Ather Energy raises ₹1,300 crore via QIP



Mumbai: Electric vehicle maker Ather Energy on Tuesday said it has raised ₹1,300 crore through a qualified institutional placement (QIP) launched on July 15 as part of its ₹2,500-crore capital infusion plan. The issue received a healthy response from foreign and domestic institutional investors, with participation from leading FIs such as ADIA, White Oak and William Blair, alongside DIs including HDFC Mutual Fund, Axis Mutual Fund and Edelweiss Mutual Fund, the company said. Ather Energy has successfully closed its ₹1,300 crore QIP, issuing 1.08 crore shares at ₹1,202 a share, reflecting strong investor confidence, it added.

Moneyboxx raises ₹50 cr from Capri Global via NCD

Mumbai: Moneyboxx Finance on Tuesday raised ₹50 crore through non-convertible debentures (NCDs) subscribed by Capri Global Capital, bringing its total NCD fundraise to ₹70 crore in the first four months of FY27. Shares ended at ₹56.33 on the NSE, down 3.21 per cent from the previous close of ₹58.20, touching an intra-day low of ₹55. The stock has fallen nearly 20 per cent over the past month and is down 9.68 per cent year-to-date, against a Nifty 50 YTD decline of 7.49 per cent. The company said the fresh debt capital would be deployed to expand lending to small and micro-entrepreneurs in rural and semi-urban India.

SBI Funds makes decent debut, ends 6.2% higher

ASSET ICON. After listing at ₹613.30, the stock ended at ₹609.75 on NSE; Equirus Securities, Emkay Global come out with bullish reports

Our Bureau Mumbai

India's largest mutual fund house, SBI Funds Management, made a steady stock market debut on Tuesday, listing at a premium before giving up part of its early gains as investors locked in profits. The stock closed at ₹609.75 on the NSE, down 0.58 per cent from its listing price of ₹613.30 but a gain of 6.2 per cent over its IPO price of ₹574; the stock climbed to an intra-day high of ₹624.80. The market capitalisation of SBI Funds stood at ₹1.24 lakh crore.

The listing follows the ₹9,813-crore IPO, which was subscribed 41.66 times, thanks to the strong demand from institutional investors, retail investors, shareholders and employees.

Speaking at the listing ceremony, CS Setty, Chairman, State Bank of India and SBI

Funds Management, said, "As a listed company, SBI Funds enters a new phase of responsibility and accountability.

"Guided by the highest standards of governance and transparency, we remain committed to creating long-term value for our shareholders while helping millions of Indians achieve their financial aspirations through disciplined investing."

He said that the company, backed by the partnership between SBI and French asset manager Amundi, is well placed to deepen investor participation and expand access to investment products.

Nicolas Calcoen, Deputy CEO of Amundi, said the French asset manager remains committed to its partnership with SBI and sees significant long-term growth opportunities in India.

"Our priority is straightforward, to continue the journey and sustain growth,"



AT THE MONEY. CS Setty (third from right), Chairman, SBI, Debasish Mishra (third from left), MD & CEO, SBI Funds Management, with the management team of State Bank of India, SBI Funds Management and Amundi at the listing ceremony of the AMC arm in Mumbai

Calcoen said. "Retail participation in investment products continues to increase. Demand for retirement and long-term savings solutions is growing. International investors are also showing increasing interest in India."

SBI NOT TO SELL STAKE On SBI's shareholding, Setty

said, "At this moment, we are not looking for any more dilution," adding that any future stake sale would only be to comply with SEBI's minimum public shareholding norms.

The IPO was an entirely offer-for-sale, with no fresh issue of shares. Following the issue, SBI holds a little over 55 per cent in the company,

while Amundi owns about 32.5 per cent. Together, the promoters hold around 88 per cent, which will have to be reduced to 75 per cent over time to meet SEBI's minimum public shareholding requirements.

ASSET BASE The fund house manages an average of ₹12.6 lakh crore in

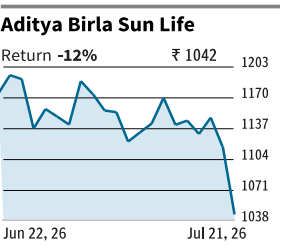
Aditya Birla Sun Life AMC net profit up 12% on better inflows

Our Bureau Mumbai

Aditya Birla Sun Life Asset Management has reported that its net profit in the June quarter was up 12 per cent to ₹309 crore against ₹277 crore logged in the same period last year, on back of steady inflows.

Revenue increased three per cent to ₹462 crore (₹447 crore). Other income was up 37 per cent at ₹162 crore (₹118 crore).

The quarter average asset of MF business was up 6 per cent in the June quarter at



₹4.28 lakh crore (₹4.03 lakh crore). Equity average AUM jumped 10 per cent to ₹1.99 lakh crore (₹1.80 lakh crore) while that of fixed income increased 3 per cent to ₹2.90 lakh crore (₹2.33 lakh crore). Passive fund AUM has grown over two times to

₹1.23 lakh crore against ₹5,300 crore.

SIP INFLOWS SIP contribution was down marginally at ₹1,085 crore (₹1,140 crore). New SIP registered in the quarter under review dipped to 5.47 lakh (5.83 lakh) while contributing SIP accounts 40.3 lakh (38.6 lakh).

Asset under PMS and alternate investment fund, including mandates, was up over five times at ₹1.94 lakh crore (₹28,700 crore).

Shares of the company were down 6.82 per cent at ₹1,042.80.

SEBI operationalises promoter share freeze mechanism for buybacks

Our Bureau Mumbai

The Securities and Exchange Board of India on Tuesday issued the operational framework for freezing promoter and promoter group shareholdings at the ISIN level during buybacks, paving the way for implementation of the amended buyback regulations from August 1.

The circular follows SEBI's July 1 amendment to its buyback regulations, which require promoter and promoter group holdings, including those of their associates, to remain frozen from

the date the board or shareholders approve a buyback until the offer closes.

BUYBACK RULES

The restriction is aimed at preventing transfers of promoter shares during the buyback period, while continuing to allow promoters to tender shares in buybacks conducted through the tender offer route and permitting invocation of encumbrances created before the buyback commenced.

Under the circular, depositors have been directed to develop the operational framework and make the necessary system enhance-



ments before August 1. The framework will specify the format for listed companies to issue freezing instructions, the modalities for implementing the ISIN-level freeze, procedures for tendering shares in buybacks, and the treatment of pledged or otherwise encumbered shares. Even where such en-

Market slips for 2nd day as crude oil price tops \$90

Our Bureau Mumbai

Benchmarks declined for the second consecutive session on Tuesday, weighed down by elevated crude oil prices hovering near \$90 a barrel, persistent foreign institutional selling, and escalating tensions in West Asia as the US-Iran conflict entered its tenth consecutive day, with Yemen's Houthis threatening a naval blockade on Saudi Arabia.

The Nifty 50 settled at 24,187, down 50 points, while the Sensex fell 238 points to close at 77,470. However, The Nifty Midcap 100 gained 0.30 per cent and the Nifty Smallcap 100 advanced 0.53 per cent.

Sectorally, Auto led the rally, buoyed by blockbuster quarterly numbers from Bajaj Auto and TVS Motor. Realty, Chemicals, and Cement also closed in the green, while PSU Banks, IT, and Oil & Gas ended lower.

LSE to go 24/7 next year

Bloomberg

The London Stock Exchange will open a new venue outside of its regular market hours, a move to offer "near-continuous trading" and better compete with the 24/7 trading provided by alternative platforms.

The new offering, which will be called LSE 24, will operate from 5 pm until 7.50 am in London and is expected to be ready for client testing by the end of 2026, according to a statement on Tuesday.

Exchange-traded products, or ETPs, will be the first tradable assets on the platform expected in the first half of 2027, with equities as a possible next step.

It's the latest example of exchanges looking to increase liquidity and attract international capital with round-the-clock trading. The NYSE, Nasdaq and CBOE have each unveiled proposals to extend trading hours to 23/5.

CME plans 24/7 trading



for some crude oil and gold futures.

TO HIRE GLOBALLY

The LSE will make hires internationally to help support the new market, Chief Executive Officer Julia Hoggett said in an interview.

Expanding continuous trading to equities will depend on approval by the Financial Conduct Authority and feedback from market participants.

Still, an expansion into continuous equity trading could create a divide between those who would rather keep trading into a condensed period and those who would prefer more flexibility around when they can buy London-listed shares.

Caliber Mining IPO gets subscribed 146.64 times

Press Trust of India New Delhi

The initial public offer of Caliber Mining and Logistics received a massive 146.64 times subscription on the closing day of bidding on Tuesday.

The IPO got bids for 114.90 crore shares against the 78.35 lakh shares on offer, as per NSE data. The non-institutional investor category fetched a whopping 267.36 times subscription, and the portion for qualified institutional buyers was subscribed 240.71 times. Retail investors' quota received 41.15 times subscription.

Caliber Mining and Logistics on Thursday raised ₹135 crore from anchor investors.

The IPO has a fresh issue of shares worth ₹400 crore and an OFS of shares worth ₹50 crore by promoters. The issue came out with price band of ₹402-424 a share.

BROKER'S CALL.

Yes Securities

KARUR VYSYA BANK (BUY)

Target: ₹375 CMP: ₹340.10

In Q1 FY27, Karur Vysys Bank's net interest margin (NIM) was at 4.26 per cent, up 40 bps year on year. The management maintained its prior FY27 NIM guidance in the range of 3.7-3.8 per cent. The management expects NIM to remain above 4 per cent in Q2. The margin (4.26 per cent) excludes the one-off interest income from the income-tax refund, which contributed 8 bps during the quarter. For the quarter, interest component in recovery from written-off accounts was ₹24 crore.

Loan growth, though a tad lower than system, was healthy in the absolute sense: The advances for the bank stood at ₹1,04,090 crore, up 17 per cent y-o-y. The bank had earlier guided that they would grow 100-200 bps above banking system growth. However, the management stated that the system has moved early and moved into corporate lending, an area they had relatively de-focused. Gross NPA additions amounted to ₹138 crore for Q1 FY27, translating to an annualised slippage ratio of 0.54 per cent for the quarter. Gross NPA additions had amounted to ₹187 crore during Q4 FY26. Provisions were ₹90 crore, down 23.6 per cent, translating to calculated annualised credit cost of 36 bps. In Q4 FY26, KVB had made a one-time prudential provision of ₹163 crore towards sectors identified as potentially impacted by geopolitical headwinds. There was no such provision in Q1 FY27. We maintain Buy rating on the bank with a revised price target of ₹375.

ICICI Securities

360 ONE WAM (ADD)

Target: ₹1,240 CMP: ₹1,185.55

We back 360 One WAM (360One)'s possible earnings trajectory to reach close to about ₹1,700 crore PAT in FY28. There has been good recovery in organic annual recurring revenue (ARR) AUM flows and stable transaction brokerage revenue in H2FY26, which continued in Q1FY27. The strategic ambition remains to double market share among client families (above ₹10,000 crore) growing from 4,000 to 8,000-10,000 families over the next three-five years. Key risks include adverse MTM movements and competitive pressure.

We expect an ARR AUM CAGR of 27.5 per cent over FY26-28, driven by net flows of ₹43,700 crore/₹56,300 crore in FY27E/28E. We broadly maintain ARR flows at about 14 per cent of opening AUM and about 15 per cent/12 per cent annual MTM in FY27/28. Transaction-based revenue, including B8K, is factored in at ₹800-830 crore for FY27-28.. We expect the cost-to-income ratio to decline to about 50 per cent/48.4 per cent, resulting in a PAT profile of about ₹1,350-1,670 crore in FY27E/28E. Based on growth opportunities and synergies from B8K acquisition, UBS collaboration and structural opportunities in wealth management, we value 360One at a multiple of 32x FY28E EPS of ₹38.7. Our estimates factor in complete dilution from UBS buying a 4.95 per cent stake and warrants issued to the promoter of B8K. Our TP has been revised to ₹1,240 (earlier ₹1,200) and we maintain Add.

businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: blmarketwatch@gmail.com

TODAY'S PICK.

Rain Industries (₹223.40): BUY

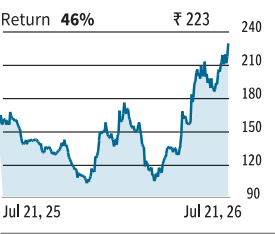
Gurumurthy K bl. research bureau

The short-term outlook is bullish for Rain Industries. The stock has been in a strong uptrend since March. This upmove is happening inside a bull channel.

The 5 per cent surge on Tuesday indicates that the upmove is gaining momentum. Support is in the ₹205-₹200 range. Immediate resistance is at ₹238, which is likely to be breached. That, in turn, can take Rain Industries' share price higher to ₹255, the upper end of the channel, in the coming weeks.

Traders can buy Rain Industries shares now at ₹223. Accumulate on dips at ₹212.

Rain Industries



Keep the stop-loss at ₹198 initially. Trail the stop-loss up to ₹226 as soon as the stock goes up to ₹232. Move the stop-loss higher to ₹237 and ₹244 when the price touches ₹241 and ₹249, respectively. Exit the stock at ₹255.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

24185 » Nifty 50 Futures

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
24130	24070	24230	24300	Go long on a break above 24230. Keep the stop-loss at 24210

₹762 » HDFC Bank

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
755	746	767	772	Go short now and at 765. Keep the stop-loss at 768

₹1071 » Infosys

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1065	1040	1080	1100	Take fresh shorts below 1065 with a stop-loss at 1070

₹281 » ITC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
278	275	283	286	Can go either way from here. Avoid trading this stock

₹249 » ONGC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
248	245	252	255	Go long only above 252. Stop-loss can be placed at 251

₹1304 » Reliance Ind.

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1300	1285	1320	1345	Go long on a bounce from 1300 with a stop-loss at 1290

₹1044 » SBI

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1030	1020	1050	1060	Go short now and at 1048. Keep the stop-loss at 1055

₹2220 » TCS

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
2200	2160	2235	2250	Go short now and at 2230. Stop-loss can be kept at 2245

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

Nifty 50 Movers					▼ 50.80 pts.
	Close(Y)	Pts	PE	WN%	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	1061.50	7.98	24.91	1.34	
M&M	3201.70	7.06	21.38	2.58	
Kotak Bank	385.95	6.27	18.91	2.57	
Bharti Airtel	1946.40	5.51	35.10	5.35	
Bajaj Finserv	1900.60	4.94	15.47	0.99	
UltraTech Cement	12094.00	4.94	43.52	1.29	
ICICI Bank	1463.10	4.54	17.56	9.46	
HCL Tech	1239.50	4.19	19.29	1.18	
Titan	4688.70	4.08	82.04	1.75	
Eicher Motors	7659.50	3.79	38.27	0.96	
Int'l Globsw	5305.00	3.76	0.00	1.08	
Bajaj Finance	1069.20	3.04	34.43	2.59	
Grasim Ind	3179.80	2.97	21.01	1.08	
Maruti Suzuki	13597.00	2.36	29.12	1.60	
JSW Steel	1267.40	2.13	11.07	1.07	
L&T	3846.60	1.99	27.92	4.07	
Tata Steel	187.24	1.50	21.47	1.40	
Bharat Elec	410.05	1.49	49.44	1.33	
Axis Bank	1258.20	1.38	14.01	3.26	
NTPC	348.55	1.35	12.27	1.49	
Sun Pharma	1961.90	1.27	40.90	1.88	
Hindalco	951.40	1.14	15.97	1.24	
Coal India	431.25	0.97	8.55	0.93	
NestleIndia	1451.90	0.88	80.01	0.94	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	240.03	0.80	76.70	0.71	
Hind Unilever	2142.50	0.54	47.57	1.72	
Apollo Hosp	8926.50	0.48	64.09	0.83	
Adani Ports	1846.50	0.40	33.28	1.23	
SBI Life	1827.90	0.33	74.23	0.74	
ONGC	249.89	0.26	6.31	2.98	
Asian Paints	2692.40	0.10	58.77	1.10	
Tech Mahindra	1576.30	-0.01	29.92	0.90	
Adani Enter	3182.70	-0.04	41.61	0.83	
Max Healthcare	1100.40	-0.33	74.25	0.74	
Eternal Ltd.	286.60	-0.55	755.68	1.87	
HDFC Life	561.35	-0.81	13.83	0.54	
Wipro	174.97	-0.88	13.83	0.45	
Cipla	1432.50	-1.12	29.97	0.73	
Tata Motors PV	333.80	-1.21	4097.76	0.63	
TataConsumerProduct	1081.50	-1.48	69.19	0.64	
PowerGrid Corp	286.70	-1.98	16.74	1.17	
Trent Ltd.	2894.70	-2.27	89.68	0.87	
Dr Reddy's Lab	1206.00	-2.28	24.21	0.60	
Bajaj Auto	10403.50	-2.88	27.50	1.04	
ITC	281.00	-3.58	16.75	2.45	
TCS	2221.10	-6.69	16.05	2.05	
Infosys	1073.50	-10.42	14.78	3.40	
State Bank	1044.40	-14.08	11.12	3.90	
Reliance Ind	1303.70	-28.62	37.14	2.10	
HDFC Bank	761.45	-54.01	14.21	10.53	

Pts: Impact on index movement

Nifty Next 50 Movers

▲ 317.05 pts.

	Close(Y)	Pts	PE	WN(%)
Tvs Motor Cmp .	3792.00	137.76	56.54	3.56
Hindustanaeronautics	4581.70	50.00	33.61	3.47
Cummins India	5583.00	30.23	65.53	3.01
MuthootFin	3079.00	29.98	11.65	1.32
Samvardhmothersinternatl	145.22	25.29	37.52	2.56
Pidilittin	1591.30	22.96	65.55	1.97
Bajaj Holdings	10446.00	18.50	11.88	1.81
Indian Hotels Co .	731.60	16.72	46.34	2.57
Hindus Zinc	534.40	16.42	16.32	1.03
Shree Cement	274545.00	15.35	56.22	1.46
Torrent Pharma	5040.70	15.05	89.68	2.56
Vedanta	264.85	14.78	6.53	1.79
Tata Motors Cv	411.75	14.57	50.07	3.43
Jindal Steel	1044.70	12.27	31.71	1.55
AdaniGreenenergy	1541.90	11.59	127.82	2.06
Adani Energy Solutions	1741.60	11.55	87.44	2.28
Bpcl	319.35	10.31	5.36	2.58
Indian Oilcorp	143.30	9.66	4.63	2.14
Dif	673.65	9.41	37.77	1.73
Global Tech Developers .	1108.95	8.51	34.91	1.33
Maruti	173.98	7.68	15.09	1.87
Ambuja Cements	440.85	5.53	19.93	1.10
Adani Power .	220.37	4.82	32.76	3.65
G Power & Ind Sol	914.85	4.78	120.40	2.50
Divis Lab	7330.00	4.43	75.77	3.72
Power India	914.85	4.23	40.07	2.41
Britannia Ind	5482.00	4.11	52.05	2.58
Punjab Natk Bank	112.08	3.20	5.82	1.54
Abb India	7532.00	2.29	101.01	1.58
Mazagon Dock	2354.10	1.68	34.46	0.71
Solar Industries	195405.00	1.20	99.24	1.85
United Bank	111.11	1.01	6.81	2.36
AvenueSuper	387.65	0.05	84.31	2.56
Bosch	40870.00	-2.27	43.47	1.42
Indian Railway Finance Corp	88.31	-2.40	16.47	0.71
Siemens	3667.80	-2.72	85.22	1.29
Tata Capital	350.55	-3.58	30.42	0.70
United Spirits	1390.80	-3.86	54.82	1.64
ZydusIntellisciences	1143.10	-4.29	22.45	1.14
Rural Elec	362.05	-5.26	5.85	1.81
Siemens Energy India .	3373.40	-5.37	91.72	1.19
Hyundai Motor India .	15958.00	-5.68	29.30	1.12
Larsen & Toubro	49.93	-6.04	23.10	1.50
Godrej Consumer	1054.20	-12.38	57.95	1.69
Canara Bank	127.52	-12.70	6.47	1.71
Tata Power	381.45	-13.81	23.82	2.54
Varun Beverages .	36.45	-18.08	48.84	2.53
Cholamandamam&Fin	1758.80	-30.17	28.65	3.04
India Infr	2541.10	-37.80	37.54	3.10
B&L of Orada	247.70	-38.55	3.38	1.83

Pts: Impact on index movement

QUICKLY.

Zaggie to acquire 20% stake in Unobanc



Hyderabad: Zaggie Prepaid Ocean Services Ltd, a spend management fintech company, has decided to acquire a 19.9 per cent stake in Unobanc Private Ltd, a cross-border payments and remittances company that owns the moneyHOP brand. It said the board of directors has approved a plan to invest about ₹7.96 crore in one or more tranches in the target company. “The move would help us expand our payments ecosystem and strengthen our presence in high-growth financial services segments. It enhances our capabilities in cross-border payments, forex, remittances and international financial solutions,” Raj P Narayanam, Founder and Executive Chairman of Zaggie, said in a statement on Tuesday. **OUR BUREAU**

Mahindra Finance Q1 PAT jumps 70% to ₹899 crore

GREEN SHOOTS. Disbursements rose 22% to ₹15,564 cr, while AUM grew 13% to ₹1.37 lakh cr

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Mahindra & Mahindra Financial Services reported a 70 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) increase in standalone profit after tax to ₹899 crore for the quarter ended June 30, as business AUM rose 13 per cent to ₹1,37,449 crore and disbursements reached a record first-quarter level. Disbursements increased 22 per cent to ₹15,564 crore from ₹12,808 crore a year earlier, while AUM grew from ₹1,22,008 crore. The net interest margin expanded to 7.3 per cent from 6.7 per cent and credit costs declined to 1.5 per cent from 1.9 per cent. Pre-provisioning operating profit rose 30 per cent to ₹1,756 crore, while return on assets improved to 2.4 per

Asset growth (in ₹ cr)			
	Q1 FY26	Q1 FY27	y-o-y change %
Disbursements	12,808	15,564	22
Business AUM	1,22,008	1,37,449	13
Total income - standalone	4,438	4,974	12
Net interest income	2,285	2,766	21
Pre-provision operating profit	1,353	1,756	30
Credit costs	660	570	-14
Credit cost ratio (%)	1.90	1.50	-44 bps
Profit after tax - standalone	530	899	70
Profit after tax - consolidated	529	927	75
Return on assets (%)	1.60	2.40	80 bps

cent from 1.6 per cent. “Our performance this quarter underscores the strength of our franchise, with continued expansion in profitability, resilient asset quality and progress in our pivot towards growth agendas,” Raul Rebello, MD and

CEO, Mahindra Finance, said. “Our focused investments in our core vehicle franchise, new growth engines and technology are supporting profitable and disciplined growth.” Consolidated profit after tax increased 75 per

cent to ₹927 crore, while total income rose 14 per cent to ₹5,725 crore.

ASSET QUALITY The company's asset-quality indicators also improved. Stage 3 assets declined to 3.5 per cent in the first quarter from 3.8 per cent a year earlier, while Stage 2 assets fell to 4.9 per cent from 5.9 per cent. Collection efficiency remained steady at 95 per cent. The quarterly performance builds on the foundation highlighted by Mahindra Finance Chairman Anish Shah in his letter to shareholders for the company's annual general meeting. He said the company had focused on enterprise management, internal controls, compliance and world-class risk processes during FY26.

Bandhan Bank's Q1 net up 35% as provisions fall 40.5%

Our Bureau
Kolkata

Private sector lender Bandhan Bank on Tuesday reported around 35 per cent y-o-y growth in its net profit, amounting to ₹501.67 crore for the first quarter this fiscal, backed by a 40.5 per cent reduction in provisions during the period. The lender had posted a net profit of ₹371.96 crore for the first quarter last fiscal. It witnessed an 18.59 per cent y-o-y fall in operating profit to ₹1,358.10 crore due to a sharp rise in operating expenses. Operating expenses rose by around 19 per cent driven by an increase in employee cost owing to the new labour codes, and the West Asia crisis that led to an increase in prices of many tech products, especially the inventory. During the first quarter this fiscal, the bank's net interest income (NII) rose 5.92 per cent y-o-y at ₹2,920.58 crore. Non-interest income, however, witnessed a fall of 16.81 per cent y-o-y at ₹603.83 crore. Provisions and contingencies during the period under review fell to ₹682.59 crore backed by around 26 per cent drop in gross non-performing assets (NPA) in absolute terms at ₹4,880.95 crore.

Q1 scorecard (in ₹ cr)			
	Q1FY26	Q1FY27	y-o-y change (%)
Net profit	371.96	501.67	34.87
Operating profit	1,668.39	1,358.10	-18.59
Provisions	1,146.91	682.59	-40.48
Gross NPA ratio (%)	4.96	3.15	-181 bps
Net NPA ratio (%)	1.36	0.93	-43 bps

Source: Bank

Net interest margin (NIM) for the period stood at 6.2 per cent, registering a 16 basis points decline y-o-y. **BETTER RESILIENCE** During a media conference call, Bandhan Bank MD & CEO Partha Pratim Sengupta said the quarter was marked by a continued focus on balance sheet quality, business resilience, and execution. “Traditionally, the first quarter has been the softest quarter for our business, characterized by seasonal moderation in growth and pressure on asset quality metrics. However, in Q1FY27 we demonstrated significantly better resilience compared to the same period of the previous year,” Sengupta said. During the first quarter of this financial year, the bank's EEB (erstwhile microfinance segment) book witnessed a marginal decline compared to the same period last year. Overall, gross advances grew 16 per cent y-o-y, while

deposits rose 7 per cent y-o-y. “Today, the saving pattern of the domestic household has changed. We are finding a gradual shift from keeping the money just parked in deposits to rather parking in various other instruments, including bonds and the capital market. Obviously, all banks are facing some challenges in garnering deposits. So, we have to find alternate ways to fund the credit needs and one of them is definitely borrowing,” the MD said. Sengupta added that the bank has also kept open the securitisation route to bridge the gap in credit and deposit growth going ahead. **FCNR DEPOSITS** The bank has so far garnered around ₹30 crore from the FCNR (B) deposit mobilisation scheme. The bank's asset quality improved as, during Q1FY27 fresh slippages came down to around ₹630 crore from around ₹1,230 crore in Q1FY26.

‘India signed 8.4 mtpa of long term LNG contracts’

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

India was the “most active” buyer for long term contracts of liquefied natural gas (LNG) in the 2025 calendar year, contracting 8.4 million tonnes per annum (mtpa) capacity, said the International Group of Liquefied Natural Gas Importers (GIIGNL). GIIGNL's 2026 annual report pointed out that the last calendar was an exceptionally active year for LNG contracting, with 83 long-term sale purchase agreements (SPAs) signed, nearly double the 47 recorded in 2024, and disclosed volumes reaching 71.6 mtpa across 76 agreements, a roughly 30 per cent increase over the previous year. It also noted that demand growth, portfolio management, and strategic procurement shaped the buyer landscape in 2025. **END-USER BUYER** “India was the most active end-user buyer, with 8.4 mtpa disclosed across six entities, including Indian Oil Corporation (4.7 mtpa), GAIL (1 mtpa), Gujarat State Petroleum Corporation (1 mtpa), Torrent Power (0.69 mtpa), Bharat Petroleum Corporation (0.5 mtpa), and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation (undisclosed), reflecting a coordinated expansion of long-term import

India was the most active end-user buyer, with 8.4 mtpa disclosed across six entities

capacity driven by rising domestic gas demand,” the international group of LNG importers said. GIIGNL said that short-term SPA activity also rose from 7 to 13, while Heads of Agreement (HOA) activity declined from 21 to 12. **MARKET IMPACT** This surge reflects the convergence of two structural forces—sustained demand growth across key importing markets, and an ongoing wave of liquefaction projects seeking offtake commitments to reach final investment decision (FID), it added. The GIIGNL report pointed out that attack on Qatar's Ras Laffan liquefaction terminal and one of the two trains of Pearl Gas-to-Liquid (GTL) plant can lead to a wider market impact. “Ras Laffan is the backbone of Qatar's gas export system, and the confirmed LNG capacity loss is already significant. However, the wider market impact could be greater because Pearl GTL is integrated into the same gas and industrial network,” it added.

Rupee under pressure from rising crude oil prices and strong dollar

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau



The rupee remained largely stable over the past week and closed at 96.24 against the dollar on Tuesday. Although the local currency declined about 0.2 per cent during the session, erasing Monday's gains, it largely held its ground amid mixed global cues.

WEEKLY RUPEE VIEW.

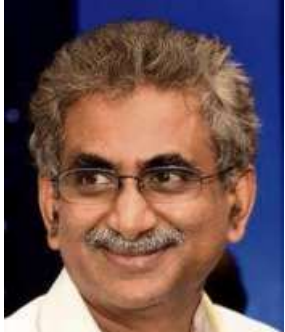
Crude oil prices have once again emerged as a key headwind. Brent crude futures, currently trading around \$90 per barrel, have surged nearly 25 per cent in July. The renewed strength follows fresh geopolitical tensions. Risks seem to be elevating after Yemen's Iran-backed Houthis announced plans to impose a naval blockade against Saudi Arabia. The development has reinforced concerns that disruptions to energy supplies remain a persistent risk, keeping pressure on oil prices and the rupee. Foreign flows, however, remained supportive. According to NSDL data, net FPI inflows stood at about \$463 million over the past week, taking the cumulative inflows in July to \$3.2 billion. On the global front, the

dollar continues to remain firm. While recent US inflation and labour market data have reduced expectations of a rate hike at next week's Federal Reserve meeting, the greenback has continued to draw safe-haven demand amid the renewed geopolitical uncertainty. Consequently, the dollar index has climbed back towards the 101-mark. More importantly, it sustains above an important level of 100.5 limiting the rupee's ability to benefit from positive foreign inflows. Overall, the rupee remains caught between supportive capital flows and renewed external headwinds.

WHAT THE CHART SAYS The rupee remained largely range-bound over the past week. However, it slipped to a nine-week low of 96.53 on Monday before recovering to close at 96.24 on Tuesday. The chart indicates that the

Ramco Cements monetises ₹1,000 crore worth assets

Our Bureau
Chennai



Ramco Cements has strengthened its balance sheet in FY26 by monetising around ₹1,000 crore in non-core assets. “Maintaining financial discipline remained a priority throughout the year. We systematically monetised non-core assets and crossed ₹1,000 crore in total disposals against our two-year target,” PR Venketraman Raja, Managing Director, The Ramco Cements, said in his letter to shareholders, as part of the company's annual report. “We deployed the proceeds to reduce net debt while continuing to invest in capacity and efficiency,” he added. He noted that this helped Ramco end the year with a “less leveraged platform from which to execute our next phase of growth.” Ramco also expects their emerging business segment of the Construction Chem-

PR Venketraman Raja, MD
icals business to clock ₹2,000 crores of revenue over the next five years. **KEY PRIORITIES** Moving into FY27, Ramco said it is focused on ramping up operations, deepening channel presence by strengthening the next generation of dealer relationships and third by sustaining financial momentum through margin recovery, costs management, and reducing net debt. Raja said energy optimisation remained a key priority during the year.

APPOINTMENTS

द फर्टिलाइज़र्स एंड केमिकल्स ट्रावन्कोर लिमिटेड
THE FERTILISERS AND CHEMICALS TRAVANCORE LIMITED
(A Schedule 'A' Govt. of India Enterprise) Registered Office Floor,
Udyogamandal - 683501, Kochi, Kerala

Assistant Manager (Welfare)
[Advertisement No.06/2026 dated 22.07.2026]
For details visit our website: [>>> Careers](http://www.fact.co.in)
Further notifications shall be available only in the above website.
Last date for submitting online application: **05.08.2026**
Udyogamandal 22.07.2026 **Sd/-**
Deputy General Manager (HR)

भारतीय कम्पनी सचिव संस्थान
THE INSTITUTE OF
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ADVT. No. 04/2026
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The Institute of Company Secretaries of India (ICSI) is a statutory body set up under an Act of Parliament, the Company Secretaries Act, 1980, to regulate and develop the profession of Company Secretaries in India. The ICSI invites applications for the following posts at its Headquarters at New Delhi/ Noida, CGRTs (Mumbai, Kolkata, Hyderabad & Manesar), Regional Offices (New Delhi, Kolkata, Mumbai & Chennai) and Chapter Offices :-

S. No.	Name of the Post	Location	No. of Posts	Pay Level as per 7 th CPC Pay Matrix (Rs.)	Gross Salary per Annum (Rs. in Lakhs)	Max. Age (as on 01.07.2026)
1.	Executive Assistant	Anywhere in India	20	Level 4 (25500-81100)	6.51	35 years

For further details viz. qualification, experience, procedure for submission of application etc., please visit website www.icsi.edu/careers on and from 22.07.2026. Interested candidates may apply only through electronic mode (Online). Last date for submission of application (Online) is 12.08.2026. Reservation policy will be applicable as adopted by the 'ICSI' in its Service Rules. The 'ICSI' reserves the right to increase/decrease or even not to fill up any posts as per its requirement.

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TVS HOLDINGS LIMITED
(Formerly known as Sundaram-Clayton Limited)
Regd office: "Chaitanya", No.12, Khader Nawaz Khan Road, Nungambakkam, Chennai 600 006.
Tel : 044-2833 2115 Website: www.tvsholdings.com Email : corpsec@tvsholdings.com
CIN : L4500TN1992PL1022845

STATEMENT OF STANDALONE & CONSOLIDATED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER ENDED 30th JUNE 2026
(Rs. in Crores)

S. No	Particulars	Standalone			Consolidated		
		Quarter ended	Year ended	Quarter ended	Quarter ended	Year ended	Quarter ended
		30.06.2026	30.06.2025	31.03.2026	30.06.2026	30.06.2025	31.03.2026
		(Unaudited)	(Unaudited)	(Audited)	(Unaudited)	(Audited)	(Audited)
1	Total income from operations	93.04	55.07	516.34	17,076.18	12,742.19	58,154.50
2	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional Items)	10.02	14.78	373.42	1,692.52	1,018.58	5,169.14
3	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional Items)	10.02	14.78	373.10	1,692.52	1,018.58	5,118.74
4	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax (after exceptional Items)	9.45	12.90	322.30	1,173.58	675.36	3,390.19
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income / (Loss) (after tax)]	6.89	10.63	317.29	1,149.78	691.00	3,889.32
6	Paid up Equity share capital (Face value of Rs.5/- each)	10.12	10.12	10.12	10.12	10.12	10.12
7	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve)	-	-	1,744.31	-	-	6,455.61
8	Securities Premium Account	36.42	36.42	36.42	36.42	36.42	36.42
9	Networth	1,759.90	1,616.50	1,750.83	5,666.66	4,030.22	5,070.00
10	Outstanding Debt	2,093.08	943.61	1,593.08	38,305.63	33,049.33	36,156.34
11	Outstanding Non Convertible Redeemable Preference Shares of Holding Company. (NCRPS)	-	-	-	-	-	-
12	Debt Equity Ratio (including exceptional item)	1.18	0.57	0.90	4.80	5.62	4.88
13	Earnings Per Share (Face value of Rs. 5/- each) (not annualised) (in Rs.)	4.67	6.38	159.30	301.62	165.85	838.12
14	Capital Redemption Reserve	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA
15	Debt Service Coverage Ratio (Excluding NBFC Subsidiary) (Times)	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA
16	Interest Service Coverage Ratio (Excluding NBFC Subsidiary) (Times)	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA
17	Current Ratio (Times)	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA
18	Long term debt to working capital (Times)	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA
19	Bad debts to Accounts Receivable ratio (Times)	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA
20	Current liability ratio (Times)	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA
21	Total debts to total assets ratio (Times)	0.53	0.36	0.44	0.56	0.60	0.56
22	Debtors Turnover ratio (Times)	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA
23	Inventory Turnover ratio (Times)	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA
24	Operating Margin (%)	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA
25	Net Profit Margin (%)	10.14	23.34	62.45	6.87	5.30	5.91

Notes:
1 The above is an extract of the detailed format of financial results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulations 33 & 52 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the financial results are available on the Stock exchange websites (www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com) and on company's website (www.tvsholdings.com).
2 Figures for the previous periods have been regrouped, wherever necessary, to conform to the current period's classification.
3 The Detailed Financial Results of the Company for the Quarter ended 30th June 2026 can be accessed through the QR code.

For TVS Holdings Limited
Sd/-
Venu Srivivasan
Chairman

TVS MOTOR COMPANY LIMITED
Regd office: "Chaitanya", No. 12, Khader Nawaz Khan Road, Nungambakkam, Chennai 600 006
Website : www.tvsmotor.com Telephone No. : (044) 28332115 Email : corpsec@tvsmotor.com
CIN:L35921TN1992PL1022845

STATEMENT OF STANDALONE & CONSOLIDATED UNAUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER ENDED 30th JUNE 2026
(Rs. in Crores)

S. No	Particulars	Standalone			Consolidated		
		Quarter ended	Year ended	Quarter ended	Quarter ended	Year ended	Quarter ended
		30.06.2026	30.06.2025	31.03.2026	30.06.2026	30.06.2025	31.03.2026
		(Unaudited)	(Audited)	(Unaudited)	(Unaudited)	(Audited)	(Audited)
1	Total income from operations	13,896.08	10,081.00	47,270.32	16,295.52	12,210.05	56,069.52
2	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before tax and exceptional Items)	1,589.45	1,050.13	4,944.89	1,545.19	977.19	4,871.82
3	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax (after exceptional Items)	1,589.45	1,050.13	4,903.52	1,545.19	977.19	4,821.74
4	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax (after exceptional Items)	1,173.97	775.65	3,615.22	1,057.61	642.86	3,186.43
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income / (Loss) (after tax)]	1,186.05	745.42	3,780.58	1,036.37	660.77	3,693.34
6	Paid up Equity share capital (Face value of Re.1/- each)	47.51	47.51	47.51	47.51	47.51	47.51
7	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve)	-	-	11,186.79	-	-	9,516.74
8	Securities Premium Account	-	-	-	-	-	-
9	Networth	12,512.49	10,720.80	11,348.62	10,201.09	9,079.92	9,187.21
10	Outstanding Debt	3,229.87	1,648.83	2,733.36	29,246.50	23,857.66	27,697.48
11	Outstanding Non Convertible Redeemable Preference Shares (NCRPS)	1,900.35	-	1,900.35	1,900.35	-	1,900.35
12	Debt Equity Ratio (Times)	0.26	0.15	0.24	2.77	2.61	2.60
13	Earnings Per Share (Face value of Re. 1/- each) (not annualised) (i) Basic (in Rs.) (ii) Diluted (in Rs.)	24.71	16.33	76.09	21.46	12.84	63.53
14	Capital Redemption Reserve	-	-	-	-	-	-
15	Debt Service Coverage Ratio (Excluding NBFC Subsidiary) (Times)	5.55	4.77	4.77	4.03	3.34	3.03
16	Interest Service Coverage Ratio (Excluding NBFC Subsidiary) (Times)	25.86	32.00	29.64	18.09	17.26	17.75
17	Current Ratio (Times)	0.54	0.56	0.54	0.93	1.11	0.97
18	Long term debt to Working Capital (Times)	-	-	-	2.65	1.85	2.46
19	Bad debts to Accounts Receivable ratio (Times)	-	-	-	-	-	-
20	Current liability ratio (Times)	0.89	0.88	0.88	0.71	0.60	0.70
21	Total debts to Total Assets ratio (Times)	0.12	0.09	0.12	0.54	0.58	0.56
22	Debtors Turnover ratio (Times)	25.86	30.20	28.08	24.47	28.21	25.66
23	Inventory Turnover ratio (Times)	23.10	17.45	20.37	16.08	12.81	14.31
24	Operating Margin (%)	12.8	12.5	12.9	11.4	10.9	11.5
25	Net Profit Margin (%)	8.4	7.7	7.6	6.5	5.3	5.7

Notes:
1 The above is an extract of the detailed format of financial results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulations 33 & 52 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the financial results are available on the Stock exchange websites (www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com) and on company's website (www.tvsmotor.com).
2 Figures for the previous periods have been regrouped, wherever necessary, to conform to the current period's classification.
3 The Detailed financial results of the Company for the Quarter ended 30th June 2026 can be accessed through the QR code.

For TVS Motor Company Limited
Sd/-
Sudharshan Venu
Chairman

QUICKLY.

Gold shines on hopes of de-escalation in W. Asia

Gold rose more than one per cent on Tuesday on hopes of a diplomatic breakthrough between the US and Iran, which could ease energy prices and temper expectations of a hawkish Federal Reserve. Spot gold gained 1.1 per cent to \$4,049.79 per ounce by 1341 GMT. US gold futures for August delivery rose one per cent to \$4,054.40. Silver rose 3.5 per cent to \$58.41. Platinum gained 1.3 per cent at \$1,614.58 and palladium was up 1.1 per cent at \$1,266.54. REUTERS

Cocoa climbs as demand revives, output set to fall



London: Cocoa prices were higher with demand beginning to pick up and production set to decline in the 2026/27 season. ICE London cocoa rose two per cent to £4,178 a tonne by 1340 GMT. New York cocoa gained 1.7 per cent to \$5,606 a tonne. Raw sugar rose 0.3 per cent to 14.87 cents/lb, while white sugar gained 0.3 per cent to \$468.70 a tonne. REUTERS

Copper hits 1-month high on Chinese shortages

London: Copper prices hit their highest in more than a month lifted by firm demand in top consumer China and declining inventories. Benchmark three month copper on the London Metal Exchange gained 1.6 per cent to \$13,835 a tonne. US Comex copper futures outperformed the LME, gaining 2.9 per cent to \$6.53 per lb for its highest since June 17. Aluminium gained one per cent to \$3,170, while zinc advanced 1.3 per cent to \$3,565. REUTERS

Nickel’s fortunes rely on Indonesia’s mining policy

MARKET OUTLOOK. Analysts see prices averaging around \$17,000/tonne this year, with the hike in quota a downside risk

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

Nickel has rebounded from the six-month lows witnessed recently, but its price direction during the current half of the year will be determined by Indonesia’s policy. “Nickel prices are forecast to ease from current elevated levels to average around \$17,500 a tonne in 2026,” said Australia’s Office of the Chief Economist (AOCE) in its *Resource and Energy Quarterly*. “Key downside risks to current prices include any upward revision to Indonesia’s 2026 mining quota (with an announcement expected in July), as well as any improvement in sulphur and sulphuric acid supply shortages,” it said. “We have revised up our

2026 nickel price forecast to \$17,000/tonne from \$16,600/tonne previously, driven by strong H1 price performance despite our expectation for prices to moderate over H2 2026,” said Research agency BMI, a unit of Fitch Solutions.

FEAR OVER POLICY
As of July 7, prices averaged at \$17,862/tonne year-to-date, supported by expectations that stricter Indonesian policy would constrain ore availability and increase procurement costs, alongside risks to domestic high-pressure acid leach output stemming from tighter sulphuric acid availability. Currently, nickel, used in corrosion-resistant alloys, electroplating, stainless steel and electric vehicle batteries, is quoted at \$16,950 a tonne, with prices up over



ZIG-ZAGGING TREND. Currently, nickel is quoted at \$16,950 a tonne, with prices up over 1.5 per cent in the past week, but down 4 per cent in the past month

1.5 per cent in the past week, but down 4 per cent in the past month. Indonesia is considering increasing its 2026 RKAB (mining work plan and quota system) mining quota to around 360 million tonnes, up from the current 250-260 million tonnes. “While the

proposal has not been confirmed by the government, it would represent the first meaningful easing of supply restrictions this year,” said Ewa Manthey, Commodities Strategist at ING Think, the financial and economic analysis wing of the Dutch multinational services firm ING.

MAY BE FLEXIBLE
BMI expects Indonesia to adopt a more flexible policy stance in the coming months to ease concerns over feedstock availability and to support production growth, which should weigh on prices relative to H1 levels. “However, a persistent market surplus should keep nickel prices above 2025 levels of \$15,161/tonne, marking a sharp jump of 12.1 per cent,” it said. The AOCE said sustained growth in global refined nickel supply is expected to contain prices around \$17,000 a tonne (in real terms) to 2031. “However, emerging supply risks raise the possibility of a tighter market balance (and higher prices) earlier in the outlook period,” it said. Manthey said if the Indonesian government goes

in for a higher quota, it would mark another shift in its nickel strategy and further cement the country’s role as the key driver of global nickel market sentiment. Indonesia accounts for 60 per cent of the global refined nickel supply. **DEFICIT IN 2026?** “The International Nickel Study Group (INSG) forecasts a relatively modest 32,000-tonne primary nickel deficit in 2026. That leaves little room for additional Indonesian supply,” she said. “We expect the nickel market to remain in surplus in 2026, but the excess is now set to narrow to 1,54,000 tonnes from an estimated 2,41,000 tonnes in 2025, as supply growth slows more sharply than demand growth,” said BMI.

KEY SWING FACTOR
It forecast refined nickel production to increase by 1.9 per cent over 2025, while pegging the growth of consumption at 4.5 per cent. “Indonesia will remain the key swing factor: Additional ore quota approvals could support higher output in H2 2026, but policy uncertainty, higher ore procurement costs and sulphur-related risks to HPAL operations will limit the scope for a stronger supply response,” said the research agency. Manthey said that if higher mining quotas result in greater downstream production, the projected deficit in nickel could quickly disappear. “For now, expectations around Indonesian policy remain a bigger driver of the market than physical supply changes,” she said.

Moong sowing dips 11% on lower rainfall

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

Moong is the only pulse crop in which the government says India has achieved self-sufficiency. Despite weak prices, farmers have largely stayed with the crop, with over 62 per cent of the targeted area already sown this kharif season.

The crop’s acreage is currently about 11 per cent lower than a year ago, mainly due to deficient rainfall in key producing States such as Rajasthan, Karnataka and Maharashtra compared with the 2025 monsoon.

However, the recent spell of rain has brought relief, and farmers expect the area under moong to at least match last year’s level, if not exceed it.

“I planted moong on June

Area under moong in kharif 2026 (₹ in crore)				
	Target	2026	2025	Change (%)
Rajasthan	26.5	17.65	19.28	-8.5
Karnataka	4.50	3.55	4.09	-13.2
Maharashtra	2.65	1.11	1.89	-41.3
All India	38.4	23.98	26.94	-11.0

27 and was waiting for rain. Fortunately, the showers on Monday will save my crop,” said Jagdeesh Chand Sou, a farmer near Dudu in Rajasthan.

Sou cultivates moong on about 35 bighas of his 55-bigha holding (around 34 acres). He said there are few alternatives apart from moong, bajra and jowar.

“No agricultural scientist or government official has ever suggested alternative crops, though farmers in our village would like to try something new because of the poor returns from

Mandi prices (₹/quintal) against MSP of ₹ 8,768/quintal			
	As on July 1, 2026	Oct-Dec 2025 against MSP (%)	Change (%)
Rajasthan	6,104	6,485	-26.0
Karnataka	6,641	4,949	-43.6
Maharashtra	9,141	8,679	-1.0
All India	6,631	6,575	-25.0

Sources: Agriculture Ministry, IMD, Agmarknet

moong,” the farmer said.

26% BELOW MSP
Despite lower prices, Sou said the crop remains viable because of its low cultivation cost. Farmers spend about

₹6,000-7,000 per bigha on cultivation and earn around ₹18,000-20,000 per bigha by selling roughly three quintals at prevailing market prices.

According to the Agmarknet portal, Rajasthan farmers sold last year’s kharif moong crop at an average price 26 per cent below the minimum support price of ₹8,768 per quintal during the peak marketing season between October and December.

Farmer leader Rampal Jat said growers in rain-fed areas had limited alternatives. Besides requiring relatively low inputs, moong is a short-duration crop (60-75 days), allowing farmers to plant another crop if rainfall remains favourable. These factors continue to make it the preferred choice despite lower price realisations.

US Met agency predicts 97% chance of strong El Nino lingering up to March

Srikrishnan PC
Chennai

The Climate Prediction Center, National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA), in its report *ENSO: Recent Evolution, Current Status and Predictions*, expects El Nino to strengthen through the end of the year, and there is a 97 per cent chance it will linger into early spring 2027.

It said that in October-December 2026, there is an 81 per cent chance of having a strong El Nino, and there is a 20 per cent chance that El Nino will be weak instead of being very strong.

WARMING OCEANS
The report said that El Nino is now established. Sea sur-

NOAA has forecast an 81% probability of a very strong event in Oct-Dec 2026

face temperatures (SSTs) are above average over the equatorial central and eastern Pacific Ocean, and the atmospheric circulation anomalies over the equatorial Pacific are consistent with El Nino conditions.

Between August 2025 and February 2026, below-average SSTs were observed across most of the equatorial Pacific Ocean.

Above-average equatorial SSTs have strengthened across the east-central and eastern Pacific Ocean since mid-April 2026, the report

added. Over the past four weeks, equatorial SSTs were above average between the Date Line and the eastern Pacific Ocean, while they were below average west of the Date Line.

The SSTs in the eastern equatorial Atlantic Ocean were below average, while in the western and eastern Indian Oceans, they were above average.

Positive SST anomalies strengthened in the equatorial Pacific, from the dateline to the eastern Pacific.

Also, above-average SSTs have been observed north of the equator in the eastern equatorial Pacific.

Above-average SSTs have increased in the east-central and eastern equatorial Pacific Ocean.

Govt to ramp up digital crop survey this kharif

Our Bureau
New Delhi

After covering 31.3 crore plots across 4.41 lakh villages during the last rabi season under the Digital Crop Survey (DCS), the Centre plans to scale it up to 45 crore plots in 5.53 lakh villages in the ongoing kharif season. The expansion comes as 10.15 crore farmer IDs have been created across 20 States.

Officials said near-real-time production estimates generated through DCS in Madhya Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Gujarat and Maharashtra had encouraged the government to expand the programme.

“As several schemes are being linked to the Digital Farmer ID, the government will soon begin providing personalised advisories on



COVERAGE DRIVE. The government plans to increase the survey to 45 crore plots in 5.53 lakh villages, even as 10.15 crore farmer IDs have been created across 20 States

crop selection as well as scientific farming,” a senior official said.

Even as the DCS is being scaled up, the government is simultaneously validating the data through remote sensing-based crop area estimation, sources said.

87% TARGET ACHIEVED
On the progress of farmer

IDs, the official said 10.15 crore IDs had already been created against the Digital Agriculture Mission target of 11.62 crore by March 2027, achieving about 87 per cent of the goal.

He added that the target was based on the number of beneficiaries under PM-KISAN, whereas the actual number of farmers is higher.

Telangana has created 49.69 lakh farmer IDs against its target of 39.78 lakh, exceeding it by 25 per cent. Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra and Karnataka have also surpassed their respective targets.

UNFINISHED WORK
In West Bengal, farmer ID creation has begun after the Agriculture Ministry signed a memorandum of understanding with the State.

The exercise is yet to start in Jharkhand, while Jammu & Kashmir, Goa and Sikkim are organising land records before rolling it out.

The official said some States had also begun preparing standard operating procedures to include non-land-owning cultivators, such as tenants, share croppers and those cultivating temple land.

Weather shocks, structural weaknesses fuel volatility in coffee, cocoa, tea prices, says FAO

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

International prices of coffee, cocoa and tea have recently seen sharp fluctuations due to structural vulnerabilities, with weather-related shocks remaining the main driver of these spikes, according to a report by the Food and Agriculture Organisation (FAO).

Price changes are not transmitted evenly across the value chain, with producers often bearing the brunt of market volatility, while consumer prices remain relatively less affected, the report said.

The FAO highlighted the need to strengthen production systems, improve market transparency and sup-

port a more balanced distribution of value across the value chain to enhance market stability and protect livelihoods.

The report, *Price Dynamics in Global Beverage Market: Trends, Drivers and Consequences*, revealed that short-term real price movements were driven predominantly by changes in supply and demand conditions, which account for more than 90 per cent of observed price dynamics.

LARGE SWINGS
“In recent years, global beverage commodity prices have risen much faster than those of other agricultural commodities,” said Boubaker Ben-Belhassen, Director of FAO’s Markets

and Trade Division.

“The combination of concentrated supply and growing global consumption creates fertile ground for large swings in their international prices. Weather-related shocks — droughts, frosts and excessive rainfall — remain the primary triggers of price spikes. Plant diseases, rising input and labour costs, geopolitical tensions, and shipping delays have added further pressures,” he said.

CONSUMER IMPACT
The report found that changes in international prices were transmitted unevenly across the value chain.

Producers are often more exposed to price swings, while the impact on con-

sumer prices is typically muted, it said. Price increases do not fully reach the farmers, while the declines are only partly reflected at the consumer level, as seen in the case of chocolate. At the retail end, international price changes have a limited impact because raw coffee, cocoa and tea account for only a small share of final product costs.

With coffee, cocoa and tea supporting the livelihoods of millions of farmers, the report warned that global price shocks “have direct implications for household income, poverty levels, food security, and government budgets, especially in countries where these crops represent a substantial share of export earnings.”

Retain longs in aluminium

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl, research bureau

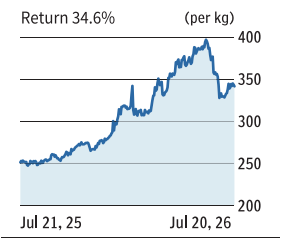
Aluminium futures (₹343/kg), after losing about 15 per cent in June, have gained a little over 4 per cent so far this month. But the trend may not have turned positive yet. The July futures rebounded from the support at ₹326 early this month.

COMMODITY CALL.

Over the last few sessions though, they have largely been trading in a sideways trend between ₹340 and ₹346. From the current level, the contract might extend the upswing to ₹350-352, which is a resistance band.

On the back of this, aluminium futures are likely to resume the downtrend again. Once the decline begins, the contract could retest the support at ₹326.

A breach of this could drag aluminium futures further down to ₹315. Instead, if the contract surpasses the bar-



rier at ₹352, the outlook could turn positive again, where it could rise to ₹360 and subsequently to ₹375.

Overall, we expect aluminium futures to rise to the ₹350-352 price band and then witness a fresh leg of fall.

TRADE STRATEGY
Last week, for traders with high-risk appetite, we suggested buying aluminium futures at an average price of ₹342. Hold on to this trade with stop-loss at ₹338.

Trail the stop-loss up to ₹345 as soon as the contract goes up to ₹347. Revise the stop-loss higher to ₹346 when the price touches ₹349. Exit the long positions at ₹350.

Despite a 33% rainfall deficit, Gujarat’s kharif planting crosses 50 lakh hectares

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad

Gujarat’s kharif sowing has remained more resilient than the South-West monsoon. Despite a 33 per cent rainfall deficit and weak precipitation across large parts of Saurashtra and north Gujarat, farmers have sown 50.83 lakh hectares — about 60 per cent of the three-year average. However, acreage under key crops, such as cotton, groundnut and paddy, continues to trail last year’s levels.

State government data show that farmers have continued sowing in anticipation of improved monsoon activity in the coming weeks.

Even so, the rainfall shortfall is beginning to reshape the cropping pattern, with several water-intensive and commercially important crops witnessing lower acreage than a year ago.



SOWING PATTERN. The rainfall deficit is beginning to alter the cropping pattern, with several water-intensive and key commercial crops witnessing lower acreage than a year ago

Eight districts — Kutch, Banaskantha, Sabarkantha, Dahod, Morbi, Jamnagar, Devbhoomi Dwarka and Porbandar — are facing “large deficient” rainfall, with the deficits ranging from 60 to 99 per cent.

Devbhoomi Dwarka recorded the sharpest shortfall at 96 per cent, followed by Kutch (87 per cent) and Jamnagar (72 per cent).

Another 14 districts, in-

cluding Ahmedabad, Gandhinagar, Rajkot, Surendranagar, Patan, Mehsana, Vadodara, Bharuch and Anand, received 20-59 per cent below-normal rainfall, highlighting the widespread weakness in the monsoon.

CROP MIX SHIFTS
Despite the patchy rain, sowing has crossed 50 lakh hectares against the normal three-year average of 85.3

lakh hectares. However, it remains below the 58.38 lakh hectares covered during the corresponding period last year.

Among Gujarat’s major kharif crops, cotton has been sown over 18.75 lakh hectares, down 4.3 per cent year-on-year. Groundnut acreage has fallen more sharply — by nearly 15 per cent — to 16.48 lakh hectares.

Paddy recorded the steepest decline, with sowing at just 2.25 lakh hectares, about 34 per cent lower than a year ago, reflecting its greater dependence on timely rainfall and adequate water availability.

Some crops have bucked the trend. Soybean acreage has increased 10.5 per cent to 2.48 lakh hectares, and pulses have also gained in area. Tur sowing is up nearly 17 per cent to 1.36 lakh hectares, and urad acreage has risen 25 per cent to about 48,900 hectares.

TATA
TATA POWER
(Corporate Contracts Department)
The Tata Power Company Limited, 2nd Floor, Sahar Receiving Station
Sahar Airport Road, Andheri East, Mumbai-400059
(Board Line: 022-67173917) CIN: L26920MH1919PLC000567

NOTICE INVITING TENDER (NIT)

The **Tata Power Company Limited** invites tenders from eligible vendors for the following package (Two Part Bidding) in Mumbai.
A) Providing Services for laying of 110KV EHV cable and associated civil work at Saki, Dharavi and Carnac RSS. (**Package Ref: CC27ASM012**)

Interested & eligible bidders for above package to submit Tender Fee, Authorization Letter before **1500 Hrs. Friday, 31st July 2026**.
For detailed NIT, please visit Tender section on website **https://www.tatapower.com**. Also, all future corrigendum's if any, to the said tender will be published on Tender section of above website (**Tata Power — Business Associates — Tender Documents**) only.

MPL
MAITHON POWER LIMITED
(Contracts Department)
Maithon Power Ltd, Village: Dambhui, PO Barindia, PIN-828205, District-Dhanbad

NOTICE INVITING EXPRESSION OF INTEREST

The Maithon Power Limited, a joint venture between Tata Power and DVC invites expression of interest from eligible vendors for the following packages:

S.No.	Ref.No	Package Description
1	3000010814	3 Years OLA for Mill Gearbox Overhauling & Spares
2	2500023866	Replacement services of RH and SH spray
3	2000093873	Overhauling of U#2 Bottom Ash Hopper
4	1500021381	Procurement of DWB Feed Gate, CG Roller and Eco Flushing (Bottom Ash and DWB Spares)

For details of pre-qualification requirements, bid security, purchasing of tender document etc., please visit our website URL- **https://www.tatapower.com/tender**
Eligible vendors willing to participate may submit their expression of interest along with the tender fee for issue of bid document latest by **31st July 26**.

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MOTILTotalA

pertain
